



HORMUZ TARGETS

Iran warns of 'crushing blows' after U.S. strikes

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DEVASTATED VALLEY

Nepal flood toll crosses 1,000 amid fresh alerts

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RIISING FIGURES

GST revenue grows to nearly ₹2 lakh crore

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DATA POINT

Workforce in the shadows

Majority of India's gig workers remain out of the government's reach

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FLYING START

Alcaraz cruises into the second round

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INSIDE



Indian killed in Russian strikes against Ukraine

LONDON
An Indian citizen was among 12 people killed in the latest Russian attacks on Ukraine, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Tuesday, as drones and ballistic missiles struck several cities in the eastern European nation. » **PAGE 14**

Cong. attacks BJP over exclusion of 2 crore voters

NEW DELHI
Flagging the exclusion of over two crore names in Maharashtra's draft electoral rolls after the special intensive revision (SIR), the Congress on Tuesday said votes were being added and deleted to ensure that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) wins elections. » **PAGE 5**

Centre's response sought on use of EVM 'totalisers'

NEW DELHI
The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought the Centre's response on the use of 'totalisers', which consolidate and count votes from multiple EVM units simultaneously without revealing booth-wise voting trends, as a "fall-back option". » **PAGE 4**

Gunmen torch homes in attack on Naga villages

GUWAHATI
Unknown extremists attacked four Liangmai Naga villages along the Imphal-Tamenglong road in Manipur's Kangpokpi district on Tuesday. They also allegedly shot at a pastor in Tapon village, and torched several houses till early afternoon. » **PAGE 4**

SC quashes cases against Gen Z protesters

Top court invokes power under Article 142 after Delhi Police say they do not wish to pursue FIRs

CJP withdraws its Sept. 5 march; Saurav Das says the outfit looks forward to compliance with order

SC says fresh FIR can be filed against those with 'criminal antecedents' spotted by surveillance

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court, at the request of the Centre, took a rare and extraordinary step on Tuesday to quash criminal cases registered against Gen Z protesters involved in nationwide protests following the NEET-UG 2026 question paper leaks. A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant exercised its absolute powers under Article 142 of the Constitution to do "complete justice" and ensure that the first information reports (FIRs) over the protests "will not be investigated, and will be closed for all intents and purposes". The court clarified its order was not confined to Delhi, but extended to all States and Union Territories. This came after a volte-face from the Delhi Police,

which comes under the jurisdiction of the Union Ministry of Home Affairs. Faced with the spectre of a Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) march on September 5 just days ahead of a high-profile BRICS summit in the national capital, the Delhi Police told the court on August 31 that it did not wish to pursue the FIRs. Following Tuesday's decision, the CJP announced it was withdrawing its call for the march. CJP co-convenor Saurav Das, who was present in the court room and was invited to address the Bench, noted the "positive assurances" of the government and the "judicial sanctity bestowed upon them" and said that the CJP looked forward to compliance with the "historic" order. The Bench, however, allowed the Delhi Police to file a "fresh and specific" FIR against 2,873 individuals with criminal antece-



Respite at last: Cockroach Janta Party co-convenor Saurav Das and other members celebrate in front of the Supreme Court after the order on Tuesday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

dents, who were spotted by facial recognition technology at the Jantar Mantar protest site in central Delhi. The court said the FIRs should not prejudice their rights, and they should be given every opportunity to defend themselves.

The top court said the Centre would be at liberty to ensure that States and Union Territories did not register any fresh FIRs with respect to the CJP-led protests held between July 20 and July 25. Keralam, represented by advocate Aljo

Joseph, appreciated the court's decision, saying that police did not respond with violence to the student protests held in the State. It further directed the Centre to frame a pan-India policy for compensat-

ing the families of students who took their own lives following the NEET-UG 2026 paper leaks, and then make the payments within three months. 'Focus on careers' The hour-long hearing ended in a general round of bonhomie with Chief Justice Kant light-heartedly saying, "All of us have seen student life." The CJ's oral remarks about 'cockroaches' and 'parasites' in the same court room had sparked the advent of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP). The CJ, after pronouncing the order, advised that students must "concentrate on careers to establish and create a space in a competitive world". The court said it chose to invoke Article 142, primarily keeping in mind the "future prospects of the young protestors". "As an institution, we

are thankful a constructive environment has been created that will help youngsters. All the best wishes," Chief Justice Kant said, giving expression to an air of satisfaction prevalent in the court room. During the pronouncement of the order, the top court asked the CJP's Das to share his statement to be included in the order. Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, who was appearing for the Delhi Police, offered to get a print-out from his own chambers in the court. Mr. Das said the statement was couched in "Gen Z lingo" and thanked the court for the "historic" order. The hearing witnessed Mr. Mehta join petitioners' lawyers, senior advocate N. Hariharan and advocate Vrinda Grover, to press for a 'John Doe' order restraining States from registering any fresh cases linked to the CJP-led protests.

Aerial palette



A rainbow over Srinagar, Jammu and Kashmir, on Tuesday. IMRAN NISSAR

'India should be vocal about international law violations'

Stanly Johny

India needs to be more vocal about violations of international law and use its global weight to push for peace between Israel and the Palestinians, says Palestinian Foreign Minister Varsen Aghabekian Shahin as she urges India to examine arms transfers to Israel seriously. In an interview with *The Hindu*, Ms. Shahin said Palestine had a "very long-standing relationship" with India and had no issue with the country maintaining friendly ties with Israel. On the two-state solution, she said there was "no other solution".

FULL INTERVIEW ON » PAGE 14

SCO must dismantle entire ecosystem of terror, says PM Modi

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) "must dismantle" the entire ecosystem of terrorism and send a strong message to countries that practice terrorism as a state policy, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Tuesday in his remarks at the 26th summit of the bloc in Bishkek, the capital of the Kyrgyz Republic. His sharp remarks came even as Pakistan took over the baton of SCO chair for 2026-27. India blames Pakistan for cross-border terrorism. Mr. Modi also called for "peace and stability" in Afghanistan. The Bishkek Declaration, issued after the conclusion of the summit, urged the Taliban administration to create an "inclusive government with the participation of all ethno-political groups in Afghanistan". "We must dismantle the entire ecosystem of terrorist financing, recruitment, radicalisation, and safe havens... We must send a strong message to countries that use terrorism as an instrument of policy and provide safe haven and support to terrorists that terrorism can never be a strategic asset for anyone," the Prime Minister said. Emphasising the need to ensure "peace and security" in the SCO member countries, he said that addressing terrorism could not be limited to an "action-reaction approach". 'Iran's sovereignty' In the Bishkek Declaration as well, SCO member states stressed "the unacceptability of attempts to



PM Narendra Modi addresses the SCO summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyz Republic, on Tuesday. ANI

use terrorist, separatist and extremist groups for personal gain". Mr. Modi said the crisis in West Asia has affected "energy security, maritime security and supply chain[s]", noting that the nations of the Global South were "bearing the greatest brunt of such disruptions". The Bishkek Declaration also placed on record the SCO's "deep concern" over the events in West Asia, expressing "support for Iran's sovereignty" and calling for a diplomatic resolution of the conflict. The Bishkek Declaration addressed both the U.S.-Iran conflict and the Ukraine-Russia war by saying that the actions of "certain countries" or groups of countries that unilaterally deploy global missile defence systems negatively impact international security. The Declaration insisted that the members of the grouping have asserted the "inalienable right to develop" and "use atomic energy for peaceful purposes and to pursue equal, sustainable and mutually beneficial international cooperation in this area without discrimination."

KEY PRIORITY » PAGE 14

NCLT Special Bench stays relief to Subhash Chandra

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

A five-member Special Bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) on Tuesday stayed an August 25 ruling by a single-member Bench of the tribunal that cleared a repayment plan requiring Essel Group founder Subhash Chandra to pay ₹6.25 crore towards admitted claims of ₹22,006.57 crore in personal insolvency proceedings against him. It also restrained Mr. Chandra from alienating his assets. The Bench found that earlier opinions in the case had failed to yield a clear majority and consequently stayed the August 25 opinion delivered by the third

member, Nilesh Sharma. The Special Bench also issued notices to the parties and sought their replies ahead of the next hearing on September 23. It assured the parties that they would be heard at length before a final decision was taken on the repayment plan. The larger Bench, comprising President Justice (ret'd) Anupinder Singh Grewal, Judicial Members Bachu Venkat Balaram Das and Mahendra Khandelwal, and Technical Members Atul Chaturvedi and Ravindra Chaturvedi, was constituted on August 31. Earlier, after a two-member Bench of the NCLT in New Delhi, comprising Judicial Member Ashok Ku-



Subhash Chandra

mar Bhardwaj and Technical Member Reena Sinha Puri, delivered a split verdict on the repayment plan in September 2025. Mr. Sharma was brought in as the third member to resolve the impasse. In his August 25 ruling, Mr. Sharma backed the repayment plan approved by

creditors holding 80.814% of the voting share. The plan required Mr. Chandra to pay ₹6.25 crore from his personal estate against admitted claims of ₹22,006.57 crore, effectively entailing a haircut of over 99% for dissenting creditors, including major banks and financial institutions. 'Independent order' However, when the matter returned to the original two-member Bench, it found that Mr. Sharma had "consciously passed an independent order" rather than concurring with either of the earlier opinions, leaving no majority view. This prompted a fresh reference to the NCLT Presi-

dent, who then constituted the five-member Bench. Meanwhile, dissenting creditors, including LIC Housing Finance and Union Bank of India, have challenged the approval of the repayment plan before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT). Appearing for the creditors before the Special Bench, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta sought to restrain Mr. Chandra from disposing of any property held by him, either directly or indirectly. Acceding to the request, the Special Bench restrained Mr. Chandra from alienating his assets. The insolvency proceedings against Mr. Chandra date back to 2024,

when Indiabulls Housing Finance approached the NCLT to enforce personal guarantees furnished by him for loans taken by Essel Group-linked entities. The proceedings concern his liability as a personal guarantor and are distinct from insolvency cases involving group companies and regulatory proceedings concerning Zee Entertainment Enterprises. Dissenting creditors had opposed the repayment plan. LIC Housing Finance had termed the payment terms under the plan "unviable and unlawful". The lender, which has an admitted claim of ₹1,322.39 crore, stood to receive only ₹38.09 lakh under the plan.

INBRIEF



T.N. CM releases water from Mettur dam for irrigation

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Tuesday opened the sluice gates of the Stanley Reservoir at Mettur for samba cultivation in the Cauvery delta. The Chief Minister reached the Salem airport around 10.15 a.m., and travelled to Mettur by road through Thoppur, Mecheri, and Kunjandiur. He opened the dam at 11.30 a.m. and showered flowers on the gushing water. Mr. Vijay also interacted with farmers and received petitions from them. The farmers urged him to release water from the dam for more days than the 45 days announced by the government.

BJP objects to SP hoarding on Ram Temple ‘donation theft’

U.P. Minister Manoj Pandey on Tuesday accused the Samajwadi Party (SP) of insulting the Brahmin community by displaying a hoarding on the alleged embezzlement of funds at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, outside the party office in Lucknow. The poster allegedly depicts Lord Ram cursing those who have indulged in embezzlement of funds, with some people seeking his forgiveness with folded hands, while others look on. Reacting to the poster, Mr. Pandey said, “The way in which the SP put up a hoarding outside its office today makes me wonder whether they (SP) are repeatedly testing the Brahmins’ patience, or are they challenging it?” PTI

BJP lawmakers compromised Odisha’s interest by supporting mining law amendments: BJD

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The Biju Janata Dal (BJD) on Tuesday alleged Odisha’s Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MPs supported the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, despite being aware that the legislation could deprive the State of nearly ₹1 lakh crore in arrears.

Addressing a press conference here, BJD Rajya Sabha MP Sanjiv Misra said the Odisha government itself had, before the Supreme Court, maintained that the amount constituted a legitimate entitlement of the State.

“On behalf of the Odisha government, Advocate General Pitambar Acharya, in an affidavit filed before the Supreme Court, had stated that the ₹1 lakh crore in arrears was Odisha’s legi-



BJD chief Naveen Patnaik

itimate entitlement and that the State would suffer substantial financial loss if it did not receive the amount,” he alleged.

Former Chief Minister and BJD president Naveen Patnaik had earlier strongly objected to the insertion of Section 9D in the Act. The new provision stipulates that any tax, cess or other levy on mineral rights or mineral-bearing land whether assessed on the basis of mineral quantity, mineral value, royalty payable or otherwise which had

not been deposited with or recovered by the State government before the commencement of the amended Act, would be deemed invalid at all material times.

The provision further states that any such tax, cess or other levy that had already been deposited with or recovered by the State government before the commencement of the amendment would not be liable to be refunded.

‘Rights snatched’

“Through the MMDR Amendment Act, the Central Government has permanently taken away the rights of State governments over mines and mineral-bearing land,” Mr. Misra said.

The BJD has no representation in the Lok Sabha, where the BJP won 20 of Odisha’s 21 seats in the 2024 general election.

No metro, costly cab rides: it’s a long, winding road to Jewar airport

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

About 70 km from central Delhi, the Yamuna Expressway leads to an airport that is pulling an entirely new landscape in its wake. In the last few kilometres before Noida International Airport in Jewar, residential towers, warehouses and commercial projects crowd the roadside, signalling a new ecosystem taking shape around it.

Inside, the contrast is immediate. The terminal is spacious, orderly and almost unhurried. But beyond the glass, unfinished stretches of land and active construction are constant reminders that the airport is still finding its feet. Two-and-a-half months after commercial flights began on June 15,



For residents of Noida and Greater Noida, however, the airport in Jewar has considerably reduced travel time. SHIV KUMAR PUSHKAR

that contrast defines the experience: a smooth airport at the heart of a project that is still catching up.

For residents of Noida and Greater Noida, the airport has considerably reduced travel time. For many in Delhi, however, cab fares and the absence of direct public transport continue to make the journey a trade-off since commercial

flights began operating on June 15.

Difficult commute

Soumit Joshi, a student from Greater Noida travelling to Lucknow, found the airport geographically closer but not necessarily easier to access.

“This is my first time flying from Noida International Airport. Delhi air-

port is farther for me, but getting there is much easier and cheaper,” he said.

Rohan Sharma, a technology professional from Moti Bagh travelling to Navi Mumbai, found the cost to be the bigger deterrent. His cab fare exceeded ₹1,700 despite travelling outside peak hours.

“The airport experience was very smooth, but without cheaper and reliable public transport from Delhi, I would think twice before using it again,” he said.

While public transport options are expanding, the network remains sparse and selective, leaving many passengers dependent on private vehicles and cabs. Passengers travelling from Delhi largely depend on private vehicles, taxis or app-based cabs. Depending on the point of origin, a cab to Jewar air-

port can cost roughly ₹1,200 to ₹3,500.

The airport authorities said Uttar Pradesh State Road Transport Corporation buses connect the airport with Noida, Greater Noida, Ghaziabad, Agra, Mathura, Vrindavan, Meerut, Aligarh, Bulandshahr, Farrukhabad, Firozabad, Garhmukteshwar, Hathras, Khurja, Moradabad and Shikohabad. Haryana Roadways also operates services to and from Fari-dabad and Palwa.

The connectivity challenge is also reshaping where the airport’s workforce chooses to live. Two employees who previously lived in south and central Delhi said they moved to Greater Noida after joining the airport to escape long daily commutes. The shift, however, came at a high personal cost. “The travel

had become exhausting, so I eventually rented a flat in Noida. Earlier, I was living with my family, but now I am paying ₹25,000 for a 1 BHK,” said an employee.

Closer to home

Residents of Greater Noida are already seeing the advantages of having an airport nearby. Mukul Rustagi said the airport had substantially reduced travel time. “It takes just about 40 minutes from Greater Noida. There is no rush and the road is excellent,” he said.

Mr. Rustagi believes the airport is changing the economic landscape. His family bought property in Greater Noida in 2018, and he said its value had more than tripled since then.

For now, Jewar has taken off. The city around it is still catching up.

Suvendu cautions media against ‘compromising on patriotism’, announces aid

Bengal govt. unveils medical cover of up to ₹5 lakh under the CM’s health insurance scheme, ₹5,000 monthly pension for retired journalists; Kolkata Press Club welcomes the initiatives

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Observing that journalists are free to engage in meaningful criticism of his government, West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Tuesday said they should ensure that patriotism never gets compromised through their work. He was speaking at the launch of social security schemes for journalists, including health insurance and pension for those who have attained 60 years.

“Criticise me and criticise the party. You can also hold constructive discussions and come to meet us if necessary. But when it comes to patriotism, everyone must follow a strict policy. None of us should do anything that weakens the country or creates instability,” he said.

The previous Trinamool Congress government had refused to implement the Ayushman Bharat scheme and rolled out the Swasthya Bima Yojana. Now, under the Mukhyamantri



CM Suvendu Adhikari (right) launching social security schemes for journalists at the State Secretariat in Kolkata on Tuesday. PTI

Swasthya Bima Yojana, those not covered under the Ayushman Bharat Scheme will be entitled to health insurance of up to ₹5 lakh, Mr. Adhikari said.

‘More benefits’

“Under Swasthya Sathi, journalists got treatment in 1,700 hospitals in the State. Under Ayushman Bharat and Mukhyamantri Swasthya Bima Yojana, you will get treatment in 1,900 hospitals in the State up to ₹5 lakh,” he added.

The CM said all journal-

ists would be brought under the scheme and beneficiaries can also avail of treatment in 38,000 hospitals in the country. He said journalists who apply for the benefit will be eligible for Durga Puja bonus. Journalists who have attained 60 years will get monthly pension of ₹5,000, he said.

Kolkata Press Club president Snehasish Sur said it is a “welcome step when the government comes forward and broadens health insurance and pension benefits for journalists”.

Protesters paint Bengali newspaper office saffron

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

A group of saffron-clad men held a protest outside the office of *Anandabazar Patrika* in Kolkata on Tuesday afternoon and painted parts of its white building saffron. After a few hours, authorities of the publication repainted the walls.

The incident comes days after the newspaper published a report on the recent clashes at Jadavpur University with the headline “*Gerua gundami* (Saffron hooliganism)”. An FIR was then registered against the paper’s editorial team.

On August 28, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari had asked the newspaper to “apologise” for the headline within 24 hours and said if it did not, people in saffron would protest.

Assam CM blames NHAI’s poor upkeep for fatal road mishap

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said poor highway maintenance by the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) led to a fatal accident near Guwahati on August 30.

Four people died on the spot after a minibus collided with a truck at Tetelia in Kamrup Metropolitan district. Three others succumbed to their injuries later. “The public claimed that potholes on the national highway caused the accident. The police, in their investigation, found that poor maintenance by the NHAI is responsible for this unfortunate accident,” the Chief Minister said after visiting the site on Monday.

He said the NHAI awarded the road maintenance work to a contractor, who failed to carry it out properly. Mr. Sarma also said Chief Secretary Ravi Kota spoke with the NHAI chairperson after the accident.

“The chairperson assured the State government that repairs would be undertaken immediately and that maintenance work would be monitored more closely in future,” the



CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at the accident site near Guwahati on Sunday. PTI

Chief Minister said, insisting that the government would take action to prevent such accidents.

He also announced ₹5 lakh as compensation to the family of each person killed in the accident.

Soon after the accident, angry locals stopped operations at the Nazirakhat toll plaza (the accident site is close to it).

Gogoi criticises BJP

Congress MP Gaurav Gogoi also criticised the condition of Assam’s national highways, alleging that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government has been collecting tolls while failing to provide safe roads. Mr. Gogoi also said that taxpayers’ money was being wasted through a “Minister-contractor nexus”.

BJP leader’s online posts spark buzz; signs of ‘imminent’ poll shocker for ruling party: Cong.

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Former Union Minister of State and senior Bharatiya Janata Party leader Kaushal Kishore’s cryptic online posts sparked a political buzz on Tuesday, with the Opposition Congress interpreting the remarks as a sign of the ruling party’s defeat in the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly poll.

“When any organisation or movement deviates from its values, it ends up back where it started, and the faith of those associated with its ideology is also shattered. Therefore, one should not deviate from its values,” Mr. Kishore said in a post on X.

The remark came a day after he wrote on X about a conversation with a friend who told him that “the ball has gone as high as it could go and it is coming down”.



BJP leader Kaushal Kishore

“Kaushal Kishoreji did not take anyone’s name, but the hint is so clear. The ball that was continuously thrown upward over the past few years with slogans of development, Vishwaguru, Amrit Kaal, and a strong government has now started coming down,” Mr. Lallu told *The Hindu* in Lucknow.

‘Not coincidence’

The Congress leader added that amid inflation, unemployment, concerns of farmers and youth, economic challenges and growing questions from the public, the BJP leader’s remarks could not be merely a coincidence.

“The truth is, it is not just the ball that is coming down, but the entire game is about to change, and the people of the country have made up their minds,” Mr. Lallu said.

Mother runs marathon barefoot to help fund daughters’ education

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

A 47-year-old mother, who works as a cook, won a marathon in Ambajogai region of Maharashtra’s Beed district to help fund her two daughters’ education.

The video of her feat went viral, where she was seen running in a saree, barefoot, holding her sandals in her hand.

The woman was identified as Ramabai Ranveer, a native of Beed in the Marathawada region. She has been the sole breadwinner of her family since her husband’s death.

“I wanted to win. That is all I had on my mind. I will buy books and fulfil other



Ramabai Ranveer taking part in the marathon in Maharashtra’s Beed. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

needs of my children. I run every day for my children’s future...today I ran for myself and the kids,” said Ramabai.

The marathon was organised on August 29 from Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Chowk to Bhagyanagar Chowk, a distance of around 3 km.



SC seeks Centre’s response on use of ‘totalisers’ in EVM vote counting

The court was hearing a petition arguing ‘totalisers’ would protect voters’ privacy by concealing booth-wise voting patterns; EC says aggregating votes could make individual EVM functioning harder to verify, as it may mask glitches or human error

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought the Centre’s response on the use of “totalisers”, which are machines designed to consolidate and count votes from multiple electronic voting machine (EVM) control units simultaneously without revealing booth-wise voting trends, as a “fall-back option”.

The court’s order to the Centre came despite a warning from the Election Commission (EC) that bringing in totalisers now, when even EVMs are subject to frequent public questioning, may not be the right move.

“It is relevant to state that the present time is one in which the functioning and integrity of EVMs are still a subject of frequent public questioning... In such a climate, the introduction of new and as yet unregulated mechanisms such as totaliser could give rise to fresh allegations and controversy, thereby further complicating public confidence in an already



The poll panel says its main worry is whether totalisers can become fodder for further misapprehension about the EVMs. FILE PHOTO

sensitive area of the electoral process,” the Election Commission (EC) cautioned.

‘No legal framework’

The EC pointed out that there was a complete absence of a legal framework – neither the Representation of the People Act nor the Conduct of Election Rules, 1961, or any allied enactment contain any provision recognising, regulating or governing the use of a totaliser in counting votes. The EC said substantive amendments and revision of statutory procedure governing the count-

ing of votes would have to be made to include totalisers in the electoral process.

“The response from political parties to totalisers is a big ‘no’. Three out of six national parties and 18 out of 29 State parties opposed the idea of totaliser. Only the Law Commission of India, in its 255th report, suggested their selective use,” senior advocate Seshadhri Naidu, for the EC, submitted.

The court was hearing a petition filed by advocate Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay, who argued that totalisers would safeguard the privacy of individual voters and

protect them from reprisals. Mr. Upadhyay said political parties victimise voters at the local level after identifying voting patterns in particular polling booths.

A totaliser connects a cluster of 14 control units of EVMs used at 14 polling stations via a cable, which in turn would provide a consolidated result for each candidate in that group of EVMs.

‘May hit transparency’

The EC, in an affidavit, said totalisers would reduce transparency. Currently, polling as well as counting is conducted in the presence of the candidates and their agents.

They are provided an opportunity through Form 17C to match vote count at the end of polling and after counting at every polling station. Form 17C data comparisons are also used at the time of adjudications before election tribunals and courts.

“The one-to-one, booth-wise and EVM-wise correspondence under Form 17C constitute the backbone of the self-verifying and trans-

parent character of the present counting process. The transparency is necessary to give credence to the outcome of the elections. This knowledge of booth-level voting pattern may be utilised by political parties to improve their outreach programme in the booths where they have not performed up to their expectations, and make corrective organisational decisions,” the EC said.

Totalisers would mask technical malfunction and human error in individual EVMs.

“EVMs clubbed together would stand concealed within the aggregate figure, and would become incapable of being identified, or independently verified by any party to the election... Totaliser, by its very design, aggregates the votes recorded across polling booths at a single point without preserving a distinct booth-wise, machine-wise trail,” the poll body said.

The EC, however, said its main worry was whether totaliser would become fodder for further misapprehension about EVMs.

Bank unions announce strike on Sept. 11; demands include 5-day work week

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Seven unions of bank employees, under the banner of the United Forum of Bank Unions (UFBU), have announced an indefinite strike from October 26, raising a four-point charter of demands, including the implementation of five-day banking, a promise made to them in 2024.

Talking to presspersons here on Tuesday, the UFBU leaders said on Tuesday that as part of their agitation, all-India bank strikes would be held on September 11, then from September 28-30, and then a “continuous, indefinite” strike would be launched on October 26 if the demands are not met.

Maintaining that the unions were forced to undertake the agitation due to the actions of the government and bank managements, the UFBU leaders said the promises made to them were not implemented.

In an agreement signed in March 2024, they said, bank managements had agreed that Saturdays would be declared holidays and unions had



Raising issues: All India Bank Employees Association leader C. H. Venkatachalam at a press conference on Tuesday. ANI

agreed that working hours would be increased by 40 minutes from Monday to Friday.

“This agreement has been recommended to the Finance Ministry, Government of India, for their approval. It has been more than two years now, but the issue is still pending with the Finance Ministry,” they said.

‘Withdraw PLI scheme’

They also urged the Centre to withdraw the “unilateral and discriminatory” performance-linked incentive scheme, prescribed by the Union Department of Financial Services (DFS).

They said the cost of the Incentive paid to 5% of the staff is far more than the total Incentive paid to the other 95% of staff, which they alleged was resulting in huge discrimination.

“Many of them have not been paid any incentive at all,” the union leaders said, adding that the DFS’s scheme is contrary to the mutually and bilaterally agreed uniform scheme.

“The DFS scheme seeks to divide the composite team of the workforce in the banks, who are today working as a unified team to achieve the targets and business parameters,” they said.

Kuki body asks its MLAs to boycott Manipur Assembly

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Kuki Inpi Manipur (KIM), the apex body of the Kuki community, has asked Kuki-Zo MLAs to stay away from the Assembly session beginning Wednesday. The Manipur Assembly session is scheduled to continue until September 7, with three sittings planned.

In a statement on Tuesday, the KIM said the resumption of proceedings should not be treated as a return to normalcy, as the community’s demand for a separate political administration remained unresolved. It said Kuki-Zo MLAs must demonstrate solidarity with the community. It warned those

who ignore the directive would be seen as moving away from the community’s collective position.

“At this critical juncture, the Kuki-Zo MLAs must stand firmly with their people. Political representation cannot be divorced from the political will of the people,” the KIM said.

The organisation maintained there can be no return to “business as usual” without a political settlement for the community that has suffered since the ethnic conflict in Manipur erupted in May 2023.

Ten Kuki-Zo leaders were elected in the 2022 Manipur Assembly polls. One of them, Vungzagin Valte, was attacked by a mob in May 2023 and died in February 2026.

Amid fresh violence, 4 Naga villages attacked, pastor shot at and houses torched in Manipur

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Unknown extremists attacked four Liangmai Naga villages along the Imphal-Tamenglong road in Manipur’s Kangpokpi district on Tuesday, less than 24 hours after three Kuki villagers were killed in the vicinity.

The Working Committee of the Tangkhul Naga Long (TNL), the community’s apex body, claimed the Kuki National Front-Presidential (KNF-P) carried out the attacks in collusion with the Kuki National Army (KNA). According to the TNL, the assailants shot at and critically injured Luithuibou Newmai, the pastor of Tapon village, and torched several houses till early afternoon.

“The attacks on four Na-



State on edge: Women raise slogans during a strike demanding NRC updation before Census 2027, on Imphal-Jiribam Road on Tuesday. ANI

ga villages were carried out by the KNF-P and KRA cadres led by Jangboi Kipgen, who is also the home secretary of the United People’s Front...,” the TNL said in a statement.

“The modus operandi of the migrant Kukis unleashing repetitive armed offensives within Kangpok-

pi is intended to effect a demographic change. The landless Kukis are utilising and employing this pattern of attacks to establish their hegemony over the ancestral land of the Nagas by uprooting us from our homes,” the TNL said.

Noting that these Kuki groups were under the Sus-

pension of Operation (SoO) agreement with the Centre, the TNL criticised the government for its alleged inability to rein in the groups under the deal.

The TNL condemned the attacks and criticised the government for its alleged inability to rein in the Kuki groups under the SoO

agreement. Meanwhile, life was affected across large swathes of Manipur – specifically the five districts of Imphal Valley – on Tuesday after the Campaign for Justice and Fair Delimitation (JFD) enforced a 24-hour general strike despite the Centre having deferred the Census exercise in the State on Monday. The JFD wants the government to prepare the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in the State before conducting the Census.

The shutdown affected business establishments, public transport, and vehicular movement in several areas, with protesters blocking roads and preventing the movement of vehicles, except those providing essential and emergency services.

PM Modi to address SRCC students on youth issues

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will address students at Shri Ram College of Commerce on September 5, during the institution’s centenary year.

This will be his second visit to a higher education institution since the protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party seeking education reforms.

During his visit, which also marks Teachers’ Day, Mr. Modi is expected to interact with young people, with the discussion focusing on their aspirations and issues shaping the next generation.

In April, he marked 100 years of SRCC by releasing a commemorative stamp in New Delhi.

Mamata’s niece found dead at home in Birbhum

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

A 31-year-old niece of former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee was found dead at her residence in Birbhum on Tuesday. Police said she was the daughter of one of Ms. Banerjee’s maternal cousins.

The police said the body was found by family members around noon. Rampurhat police inspector Santanu Adhikary said family members stated she had been suffering from severe depression and was also probably stressed due to divorce proceedings.

She lost her job at a high school in March 2023 after the High Court terminated services of employees over alleged irregularities in the School Service Commission exam in 2016. (Those in distress may avail counselling at Tele MANAS 1800-89-14416.)

Trinamool worker tortured in police custody: Abhishek

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Tuesday alleged that a party worker, arrested in connection with a dispute over a signboard, was allegedly tortured in police custody, leaving him with a serious head injury.

“They [BJP government] believe that threats and intimidation can decide the future of democracy. I want to remind them that in a democracy, a ruler never speaks the final word. The people speak,” he said. “If they think they can silence us through false cases and arrests, they are mistaken,” he added.

Mr. Banerjee said the party worker was arrested and “subjected to custodial torture”. “Another 12 or 13 others remain in judicial custody. Many were arrest-

Trinamool general secretary says party members detained without prior notice

ed without prior notice, and there were multiple procedural errors,” he said. The Trinamool leader, who appeared before the police on Tuesday in connection with the case, was interrogated for nearly six hours.

The Kolkata Police registered FIRs against Mr. Banerjee and Rajya Sabha MP Derek O’Brien on Friday for allegedly assaulting police and obstructing them from discharging their duty when they went to remove the signboard.

In a stand-off lasting almost 90 minutes, Trinamool workers engaged in a heated exchange with police officers and civic body officials.

Over 7,200 CBI cases under Prevention of Corruption Act pending trial, says CVC report

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Over 7,200 cases probed by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) under the Prevention of Corruption (PC) Act were pending trial as on December 31, 2025. Of these, more than 400 cases were pending for over 20 years, according to the annual report of the Central Vigilance Commission (CVC).

Apart from the 7,229 cases under the Prevention of Corruption (PC) Act awaiting completion of trials, there were 14,083 appeals, revisions, and writ petitions pending under the Act in the High Courts and the Supreme Court. Of them, 3,161 were 10-15 years old, while 1,347 were 15-20 years old, and 739 were over 20 years old.

In 2025, the conviction rate in CBI cases was 71.7%



14,083 appeals, revisions, and writ pleas under the PC Act are pending in HCs and the SC.

against 69.14% for 2024. At the end of the year, 11,510 court cases (including the cases not registered under the PC Act) were pending under trial in various courts.

Last year, the agency had 755 corruption-related cases pending investigation. They included 679 regular cases, 63 preliminary enquiries, and 13 Lokpal references. Of the 679 regular cases, 274 had been pending for over one year. During the year, the

CBI registered 797 regular cases, 177 preliminary enquiries, and recorded 31 Lokpal references.

1,088 vacancies

As of December 31, 2025, sanctioned strength of the CBI was 7,300. However, there were 1,088 vacant positions. The largest vacancy of 672 posts was in the executive ranks. For officers under CVC jurisdiction, 1,460 departmental inquiries were under process during last year, of which 731 were completed. For employees outside its purview, 9,883 departmental inquiries were under process, of which 5,561 were completed.

As many as 34,153 complaints, besides 1,260 carried forward from 2024, were received by the Commission during 2025. It disposed of 35,193 complaints.

Supreme Court to hear Gadling’s bail plea on October 14

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court said on Tuesday it would hear on October 14 a bail plea filed by advocate and activist Surendra Gadling in connection with the 2016 Surjagarh iron ore mine arson case.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Mr. Gadling, told a Bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Augustine George Masih, and Sandeep Mehta that his client had been incarcerated for over seven years. He pointed out Mr. Gadling was also an accused in the Elgar Parishad-Maoist links case and had already been granted bail in that one.

Additional Solicitor General S.V. Raju, appearing for the Maharashtra government, urged the Bench to list the matter on a non-miscellaneous day to allow for a detailed hear-



Surendra Gadling

ing. The present plea arises from the 2016 Surjagarh arson case, in which vehicles transporting iron ore in Gadchiroli were allegedly set ablaze by persons associated with the Communist Party of India (Maoist).

On January 31, 2023, the Nagpur Bench of the Bombay High Court rejected his bail plea, observing that the allegations concerning his membership of the banned organisation appeared *prima facie* true. The bail plea has since faced repeated delays.

Congress accuses Centre of 'statistical gymnastics' over GDP growth figures

Nadda hails CJP's decision to call off Sept. 5 protest

Dipke hails quashing of FIRs against students

HC seeks response on MP's plea against social media page suspension

During the hearing, Meta's counsel told the court that the MP's Facebook page was taken down pursuant to a notice issued by a law enforcement agency.

SCIENCE

A hidden eight-note alphabet makes up every bird song in the world

The study finds that in tropical rainforests such as in Southeast Asia, birds prefer simpler songs that travel efficiently through dense vegetation, but in temperate regions such as Europe and North America birds inhabit smaller territories and have short breeding seasons, information-rich songs

Nikhil Sreekandan
BENGALURU

From the musical whistles of a red-whiskered bulbul to the mechanical whirr of a barn swallow song, there is an incredible diversity to avian music. But according to a new study by researchers from France and the U.S., this vast diversity comes from just eight building blocks.

Researchers analysed more than one lakh song recordings from more than 3,000 passerine bird species worldwide using machine learning to reveal the eight core motifs, or basic sounds.

These motifs consist of three types of trills (repetition of the same note) distinguished by their speed, three types of whistles based on their pitch modulation, and two other complex sounds.

“If you go to different countries in the world, you will hear totally different [bird] songs,” said Quentin Bacqué, one of the paper’s authors and a PhD student at the Universities of Montpellier and Saint-Étienne, France.

The central question of their study was whether it was possible to characterise the songs into broad types, Mr. Bacqué added.

The researchers also did not just deconstruct birdsong down to their sound: they also found that where birds reside influences the sounds they use.

Infinite possibilities

By sourcing data from Xeno-canto, a citizen-science repository of verified wildlife audio recordings, the researchers could analyse birdsong recordings from almost everywhere on the planet. But Mr. Bacqué said it also meant there was data disparity, with more recordings coming from Europe and the Americas than Africa.

First, the team denoised the recordings to focus on the species of interest, then converted them into high-resolution spectrograms – visual maps that show sound frequencies over time. Following this, the researchers computed a modulation power spectrum (MPS) for each song, which reduced the acoustic signals to the constituent patterns of frequency and temporal modulation.

While less precise than a spectrogram, an MPS can provide a broad perspective on timbre, pitch, tonality, and rhythm, Mr. Bacqué said.

“That’s really useful because when you have thousands of songs, you don’t want to know every detail. Instead, you want to know how similar one song is to another.”

The researchers were then able to explore the variability of these songs inside a 37-dimensional acoustic space (a 3D representation of which is available online). “It’s like all these differently shaped clouds altogether, where proximity reflects spectro-temporal similarities,” Mr. Bacqué said.

With the help of machine learning,



A red-whiskered bulbul in Satchari National Park, Bangladesh, in 2018. NAFIS AMEEN (CC BY-SA)

researchers found that all songs concentrate around eight poles in the acoustic space, each captured by a specific motif. These motifs included three types of trills – slow, fast, and ultrafast; three types of whistles – flat, slow-modulated and fast-modulated; atonal chaotic notes, which are harsh, rough sounds; and harmonic stacks, where there are several low- and high-pitched tones at once, like in the song of a crow.

The main finding is that these motifs serve as building blocks, with bird species using just one or all eight in their songs, said Pooja Choksi, co-founder and lead scientist at India Ecoacoustics Network. She was not involved in the study.

“This is a great attempt to classify and generalise across such a large group of species,” Ms. Choksi said. “At the end of the day, motifs are simply characteristics of a song, and there will probably always be a debate on how to characterise something.”

Environmental constraints

Per the study, birds, on average, use five motifs and which depends largely on their evolutionary history. “If an ancestor is using a certain motif, there is a huge chance [the current generation] is using the same motif,” Mr. Bacqué said.

Social organisation, morphology, and mating systems were the other

determining factors. Researchers found that birds communicating over long distances tend to use simple motifs like flat whistles and slow trills whereas those signalling at close range favour faster, more complex motifs.

Similarly, simpler sounds are represented better in larger birds and more challenging motifs are predominant in smaller species. Finally, their analysis revealed that groups facing intense sexual selection pressures tend to use complex motifs while species subject to weaker pressures use simpler ones.

“Song motifs are essentially a trade-off between encoding more information and transmitting it over long distances,” Mr. Bacqué said. “And what we found is this trade-off is different between temperate and tropical forests.”

Upon mapping the global geographic distribution of motifs, they found that in tropical rainforests such as in Southeast Asia, birds prefer simpler songs that travel efficiently through dense vegetation. In temperate regions such as Europe and North America, on the other hand, birds have small territories and short breeding seasons, and complex, information-rich songs.

This is the biggest finding from their research, according to Mr. Bacqué: it reveals how environmental constraints shape birdsong at a planetary scale.

“It makes logical sense that species

have adapted their songs for optimal transmission in their local environment,” Ms. Choksi said. “But it is interesting to see this pattern in such a large global analysis.” She also questioned whether the patterns would hold at much finer spatial resolutions. “The [motifs] are broad categories, and within each, there can be a lot of variation in frequency and shape,” said Elodie Briefer, an associate professor at the University of Copenhagen who was not involved with the study. So there is variation among species that share spaces, according to Ms. Briefer, whose research focuses on animal cognition and communication.

The birds themselves perceive many more nuances within these eight motifs, Ms. Briefer, who has worked closely with skylarks, added. She was, however, interested in building on this research and exploring how birds perceive these eight motifs and whether any factors influence the order in which motifs are used.

Ms. Choksi said she believes it is worth studying how habitat changes affect birdsong and mating success and reproduction. This is particularly true in India, where invasive species have proliferated and tree-planting is almost out of control, she added.

(Nikhil Sreekandan is an independent journalist. nsreekandan@gmail.com)

THE GIST

- Despite the immense diversity of birdsong across different regions, the study found that these sounds can be grouped into a limited set of fundamental categories
- On average, birds use five of the eight song motifs, the study says, with the selection largely shaped by their evolutionary history
- The study’s most important finding is that environmental constraints influence birdsong patterns, shaping how birds communicate at a planetary scale

BIG SHOT



Safety suit: Penguins wear copper bodysuits designed to speed recovery after surgery for wounds often caused by entanglement in fishing nets, as the copper and zinc help prevent bacterial growth, at the Humboldt Conservation Centre, in Coquimbo, Chile, on August 27. REUTERS

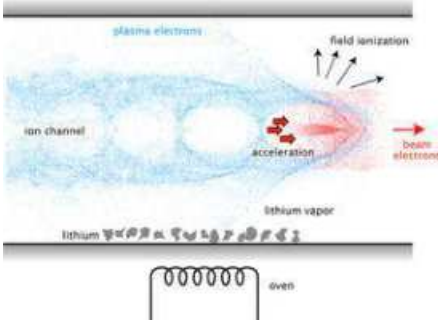
WHAT IS IT?

Wakefield accelerator

Vasudevan Mukunth

When you hear the word ‘particle accelerator’, you probably think of a giant machine with many complicated parts, and why not? Many of the world’s particle accelerators are several hundred metres long. The world’s largest science experiment is also an accelerator: the Large Hadron Collider (LHC) in Europe, which uses an assembly of powerful magnets and electric currents to push protons to nearly the speed of light through a 27-kilometre metal tube.

But not all accelerators have to be big. A technology called wakefield accelerator can fit atop a table. Such an accelerator uses a wave of plasma to push charged particles. A plasma is a gas in which some electrons have been pulled out of their atoms, creating a mix of free electrons and positively charged ions. When a laser pulse or beam of charged particles passes through the plasma, it will push the electrons aside. After the pulse or beam has departed, the ions will ‘pull’ the electrons back. But the electrons will overshoot and then oscillate back and forth, creating a travelling pattern of alternating electric fields. If you inject other electrons into this pattern, at just the right point, they



An illustration of a plasma wakefield accelerator in action. RASMUS ISCHEBECK (CC BY-SA)

can surf the moving electric fields like a surfer on a big ocean wave, drawing energy from the wave itself.

Such wakefield acceleration can produce electric fields that impart more energy to electrons across some small distance than a conventional accelerator might. However, current designs cannot accelerate electrons to more than a few tens of GeV, whereas the LHC can achieve up to three orders of magnitude more.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



The seemingly apolitical Gen Z youth

In the elections to the State Assemblies of Kerala, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Assam, and the Union Territory of Puducherry, one emerging pattern had been the engagement, or lack thereof, of the younger generation, the Gen Zs in particular, in the electoral process. Gen Zs are often seen as apolitical, or even anti-political, judged by the positions they take on issues, and by their preoccupation with the present rather than the past or the future.

Yet being apolitical, or claiming to be, is itself a way of falling victim to the dominant political narrative. The point here is not to pass judgment on the Gen Z youth, but to insist that politicising this generation is necessary not just for democratisation but for their own reclaiming of rights within the Indian union. One of the first steps toward that end is to ensure that every educational institution has an elected students’ council.

Gradual depoliticisation

Over the last few decades, especially since the 1990s, depoliticisation, a strategic project of neo-liberal capitalism, has been on the rise. This is primarily because depoliticisation is structurally engineered; it treats the citizen as a consumer. Individualism has become the prominent ideology, converting unemployment, housing, and other livelihood crises into personal failures.

Then there is what might be called a culture of ‘nano impulsiveness’. Every generation is new in relation to the one before it, but the terms of that newness are often contested. Neoliberalism shortens the temporal horizon itself, and



Tikender Singh Panwar

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this shrinking of attention is visible across commerce, psychology, and everyday behaviour. It breeds a politics of spontaneity and impulse. Thus, a depoliticised Gen Z becomes the ideal subject for personality cults and social media-manufactured consent, voting for a face or a moment rather than a programme – a tendency that hyper-nationalist, emotionally-charged messaging exploits with ease, especially in the absence of counter institutional spaces such as students’ or trade unions.

A revival

However, the summer of 2026 offered a sharp rebuttal to the thesis that Gen Z is inherently apolitical. The protests that erupted at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar over irregularities in the NEET-UG examination drew thousands of students to the capital. What was most striking was not just the scale of mobilisation but its texture – young protesters bypassed government imposed mobile Internet shutdowns using peer-to-peer Bluetooth mesh networks; ran a mobile library for fellow demonstrators; and found millennials marching alongside them, dissolving a generational divide both sides had long taken for granted. Gen Z, it turned out, was never apolitical; it was waiting for a cause that felt like its own, and a means to organise around it.

Political parties, many of whom themselves emerged out of student movements, have been the ones banning students’ unions. West Bengal banned students’ elections a decade ago. Tamil Nadu did the same decades earlier. Most

Bharatiya Janata Party-ruled States do not hold elections to students’ councils.

Keralam remains the exception, with regular student union elections. These elections produce politically literate constituencies with a sustained capacity for democratic engagement – precisely what is anathema to neo-liberal capitalism. Such engagement is often the first step in shedding an identity rooted in ethnicity, religion, or caste, and acquiring one rooted in democratic demands around education and employment.

One often hears that student politics cause disruption – an argument that even parties which claim to oppose neoliberalism have adopted wholesale. But education is not a factory floor; a campus without politics produces obedient labour, not democratic citizens.

The depoliticisation of the Gen Z youth is not their own failure but the success of a system engineered to produce this outcome. If the 1970s saw large, sustained movements shaped decisively by students and their unions, today that participation matters just as much, as the Jantar Mantar protests have shown us. The task is not to instill an interest in politics in this generation; Jantar Mantar shows they already possess it but are waiting for it to take an institutional form.

The answer to depoliticisation is not to lament Gen Z’s apathy but to restore the institutional conditions under which political consciousness has always been formed – campus democracy, student unions, and the right to deliberate collectively.

All animals need equal consideration

On June 9, a Supreme Court division Bench observed that the court cannot remain a mute spectator in matters concerning animals, noting that their wellbeing is of paramount importance. The court’s observation in this case (*Jayakrishna Menon vs. Krishnankutty & Ors*) arose from an ownership dispute over Raman, Keralam’s tallest elephant, who was being used for temple activities. Raman’s temporary custodian was responsible for care and upkeep but the elephant continued to be used for temple activities despite it being prohibited by the top court. The SC ordered the Keralam government to take custody of Raman, emphasising that it would fail in its duty towards “voiceless animals” if it turned a blind eye to such defiance of court orders.

Two different approaches

The court’s observation implicitly acknowledges an animal’s propensity to suffer while highlighting the need to ensure the wellbeing of animals. However, the approach adopted by the SC in this case stands in sharp contrast to its ruling on the issue of street dogs in *Re: City Hounded by Strays, Kids Pay Price*, 2026, where a three-judge Bench adopted a much narrower interpretation of the law which led to the removal of a large numbers of dogs from public institutions.

The judiciary’s differential treatment of these two categories of animals – elephants and street dogs – raises important moral and legal questions. For instance, why is one elephant’s wellbeing of “paramount importance”,

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while the welfare of lakhs of street dogs is disregarded? Further, how is it that the same institution adopts two contrasting (if not contradictory) approaches to decide issues involving similar moral considerations? And importantly, is the judiciary the best positioned institution to decide cases that seal the fate of animals (for better or for worse)?

However, one needs to acknowledge that these two cases and the animals at the centre of them are not identical. The legal protections these two animals are entitled to, and their interactions with humans vary significantly. The Indian elephant is a charismatic animal, listed as an Endangered Species on the International Union for Conservation of Nature’s Red List, and is explicitly protected under the Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972. The street dog, on the other hand, is legally perceived as a problem that needs to be tackled. One is expected to live in the wild (away from human habitation) while the other shares our public spaces, requiring us to learn to coexist in shared spaces.

While it is important to recognise these differences, it is also crucial to question whether they are significant enough to attract completely different moral and legal considerations.

As moral philosopher Peter Singer has argued, the basic principle of equality does not require equal or identical treatment; it requires equal consideration. For Singer, equal consideration is extended to every being that has interests, has some subjective awareness, or is capable of feeling pleasure or pain. Singer accepts that

equal consideration for different beings may lead to different treatment and different rights. However, when comparing the two judgments in question, it is the absence of equal consideration itself that seems to be leading to the differential treatment. Equal consideration, in both these cases, would require an assessment of the needs of the animals, and then the determining of a relevant course of action.

Anthropocentric bias

There is also a similarity in the approach of the laws that govern these animals. The Wildlife Protection Act for elephants, and the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960 that apply to street dogs reveal an anthropocentric bias in evaluating the worth of animals, which in turn determines the nature and level of protections they are entitled to.

Two different cases involving different animals presented contrasting approaches to the treatment of animals by the SC. This highlights a gap in legislative guidance for ensuring the well-being of animals, different as they may be in their categorisation in the eyes of the law. The Swiss Constitution, for example, not only ensures the well-being of animals but also ensures the protection of animal dignity which grants animals an inherent worth. This responsibility ultimately lies with the Parliament which should extend protection to every being worthy of moral consideration. We need a strong legislative foundation which provides moral consideration to all animals and enables pathways for ethical coexistence.

Majority of India’s gig workers remain out of govt.’s reach

While the number of registrations by gig workers on the e-Shram portal have increased, it has not been uniform across States

DATA POINT

Sachin Swaraj

The Union government, recognising the contribution of gig workers to the “new age services economy” in its 2025-26 Budget, announced healthcare coverage for gig workers who are registered on the e-Shram portal launched in 2021. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, who made the announcement in her Budget speech on February 1, 2025, said the measure is expected to benefit over one crore gig workers.

Though the registration of gig workers has since gained momentum, the gap in numbers not only shows that a majority of such workers are yet to benefit from the announcement, but also points to inadequacies in measuring and understanding the rapidly growing size of the country’s gig workforce.

While the Minister quoted the figure of one crore, the e-Shram portal has seen the registration of only 8.58 lakh gig workers as per a reply presented by the Ministry of Labour and Employment in the Rajya Sabha on January 29, 2026 – the latest date for which the data has been made publicly available. Even if one assumes the registrations to have doubled since January, it would account for only around 15% of the estimated number of gig workers.

This means that five out of every six gig workers remain outside the government’s reach.

The size of India’s gig workforce, often quoted to be over one crore in many of the government’s replies in Parliament last year, seems to emerge from a single source – the NITI Aayog’s ‘India’s Booming Gig and Platform Economy’ report released in June 2022. The report estimated the number of workers to be around 77 lakh in 2020-21. **Chart 1** shows the gap between the estimated number of gig workers and those registered on the e-Shram portal.

In the absence of dedicated efforts to measure the size of its gig workforce, India’s estimates have solely relied on this NITI Aayog report, which estimates the number of gig workers in 2024-25 and 2025-26 to be 1.27 crore and 1.43 crore respectively.

By conceptualising the portal as an Aadhaar-seeded ‘National Database of Unorganised Workers (NDUW)’, and making registration a prerequisite for availing benefits, the government has made e-Shram the unified platform for tracking its unorganised workforce, including gig workers.

The Periodic Labour Force Survey reports are yet to capture gig workers as a distinct category despite the estimated gig workforce accounting for about 2% of India’s total workforce of 61.6 crore, as cited by the 2025 PLFS report.

The government officially defined who a gig worker is only in the Code on Social Security, 2020, which came into force last year. The Code promised more benefits, such as accident insurance, maternity benefits, and a dedicated social security fund, but most are yet to materialise.

The promise of health coverage in the 2025-26 Budget seems to have however driven a surge in registrations. **Chart 2** shows the growth in the registration of gig workers on e-Shram.

However, the registrations have not been uniform across States. **Chart 3** shows the top 10 States with the highest number of registrations. Notably, highly urbanised Tamil Nadu (31,654), Telangana (29,951) and Kerala (11,219) are not even among the 10 States.

NITI Aayog’s 2022 report listed 21 sectors that had gig workers. While this included agriculture, healthcare, education, and retail, the concentration of gig workers has been in the food industry, transportation, and domestic and household work, as per registrations on e-Shram. **Chart 4** shows the top 5 sectors with the highest share of gig workers.

Delivery failure

The data were sourced from NITI Aayog and the Ministry of Labour and Employment’s replies to Parliament. Chart 2 and 4 include data sourced from Dataful. Sachin Swaraj is a student of Azim Premji University, interning with The Hindu’s Data Team



CHART 1: India’s estimated number of platform workers and those registered on the e-Shram portal

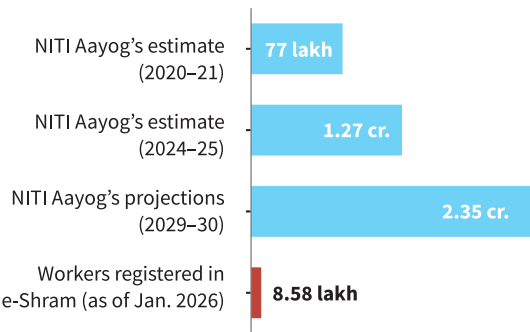


CHART 2: The registration of gig workers on the e-Shram portal has seen a sharp increase since 2025

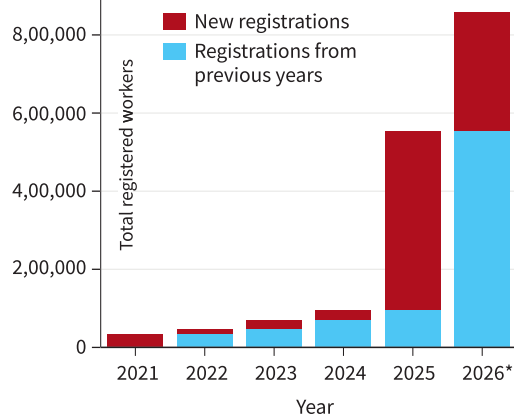


CHART 3: The 10 States with the highest number of gig workers registered on the e-Shram portal as of January 2026

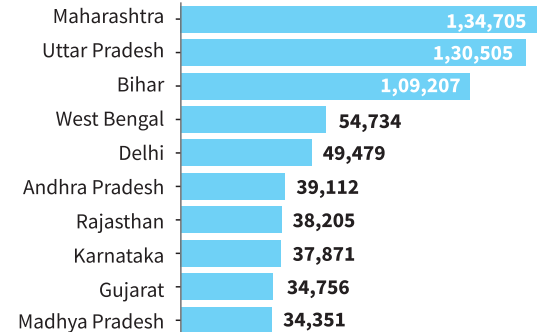
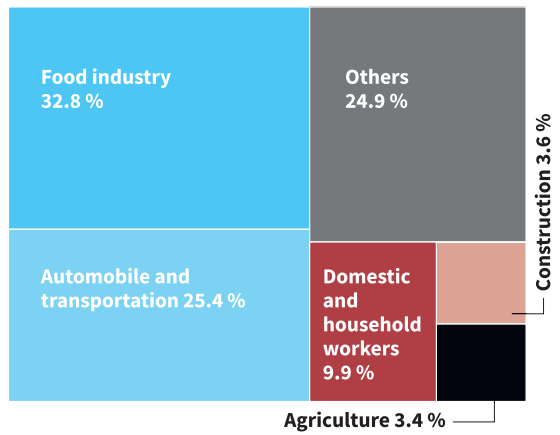


CHART 4: The five sectors that employed the highest share of gig workers, based on registrations on e-Shram



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 2, 1976

Synthetic blood protein

San Francisco, California, September 1: Researchers are close to creating synthetic blood protein which may speed them towards cure for sickle-cell anaemia and other blood disorders, a scientist has reported.

According to Dr. Sherman Beychok scientists at the Columbia University in New York City have learned how to take apart a molecule of human haemoglobin and put it back together. This removes the major stumbling block to creation of man-made haemoglobin.

Haemoglobin is the basic respiratory unit of blood, the protein that carries oxygen from the lungs to body tissues.

Dr. Beychok said scientists could learn more about blood disorders by duplicating the sickle-cell haemoglobin molecule, for example, and comparing it with synthetic molecules of healthy haemoglobin.

Dr. Beychok, whose findings are to be presented in a report to the American Chemical Society, said scientists have long had the knowledge to create synthetic protein chains that would duplicate those in haemoglobin. But, he said, the Columbia research would enable them for the first time to bind the chains together with “heme” the other basic component of haemoglobin, without having the volatile protein chains fall apart.

“Heme” contains the atom of iron that grabs an atom of oxygen to carry it to body tissues. Dr. Beychok said “Heme” – “available from a bottle on a shelf” – is easily produced from cow’s blood. Dr. Beychok stressed that artificial haemoglobin could not replace whole blood transfusions or keep a trauma patient alive indefinitely unless it was replenished by transfusion or by the victim’s own blood.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 2, 1926

Theft in Darbhanga Maharaja’s palace

Calcutta, September 1: Information has been received in Calcutta of a daring theft, recently committed in the palace of the Maharajadhiraja Bahadur of Darbhanga. Three rings worth Rs. 68,000 were stolen. One of the rings, valued about Rs. 60,000 was set with a single rose diamond that at different times of day changed colour from rose to white or blue. Vigorous police investigation is proceeding.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Jharkhand districts in which flash flood alerts were issued

10 The Jharkhand weather department has issued a flash flood warning for 10 districts as heavy rain lashed large parts of the State on Tuesday. Dumaria in East Singhbhum registered the highest 217 mm of rain since Monday, the India Meteorological Department said. PTI

Onion stock for PDS that reached Chennai via Kanda Express

840 in tonnes. The second 'Kanda Express' — a dedicated railway rake carrying 840 tonne of onion from the buffer stock — reached Chennai on August 31, with the Tamil Nadu government planning to distribute 1 kg onion per ration card via the Public Distribution System (PDS). PTI

Number of corruption cases pending trial as of December 2025

7,229 As of December 31, 2025, a total of 7,229 corruption cases probed by the CBI were pending trial in courts, including 409 cases pending for more than 20 years, according to the Central Vigilance Commission's 2025 annual report. PTI

Keralam's monsoon rainfall deficit from June to August

22 in per cent. Keralam received 1,367.1 mm of rainfall during the southwest monsoon from June 1 to August 31, 2026, which was 22% below the normal rainfall of 1,746.8 mm, according to IMD data. Wayanad recorded the highest deficit among districts at 50 per cent, followed by Idukki at 44%. PTI

Share of asylum requests denied in the U.S. in June 2026

94.1 in per cent. U.S. immigration court data showed that 94.1% of asylum cases were denied in June 2026, while only 5.5% were granted, according to figures reported by the Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse (TRAC). PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Untouchability and the idea of ‘purity’

How does Indian law define ‘untouchability’? How has the Supreme Court interpreted ‘purity and pollution’? What did the Rajasthan High Court rule on purification? What facts would determine whether the Haldwani ritual amounted to untouchability?

LETTER & SPIRIT

Sahil Hussain Chaudhury

The story so far:

A *shuddhikaran* (purification) ritual was performed at Haldwani’s Ramlila ground on August 10, two days after Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge addressed a rally there. Mr. Kharge said the ritual made him feel the “sting of untouchability” and sought legal action, while the organisation that performed it offered a different explanation, citing slogans allegedly raised during the rally and Mr. Kharge’s earlier political remarks. The dispute raises a legal question beyond the immediate controversy: what does Indian law regard as untouchability when the alleged wrong is not denial of entry, but the “purification” of a place after a Dalit person has used it?

What does the law prohibit?

Article 17 of the Constitution declares that “untouchability” is abolished”, forbids its practice “in any form”, and says that enforcing any disability arising from untouchability shall be an offence punishable in accordance with law. The Supreme Court has recognised that Article 17 is enforceable against non-State actors as well.

The Constitution does not define “untouchability”.

Parliament gave effect to Article 17 through the Untouchability (Offences) Act, 1955, which was substantially amended and renamed the Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955 in 1976. The Act punishes the preaching and practice of untouchability and the enforcement of disabilities arising from it.

Some of its provisions address familiar forms of untouchability: preventing entry into a place of worship, imposing social disabilities, or discriminating in access to public facilities and services. But the law is not confined to physically keeping somebody out. Section 7(1)(d) also punishes a person who “insults or attempts to insult, on the ground of ‘untouchability’, a member of a



Show of dissent: Congress workers march towards the Uttarakhand Secretariat in Dehradun on Tuesday, protesting a ‘purification’ ceremony at the venue of Mallikarjun Kharge’s Haldwani rally. PTI

Scheduled Caste”.

The law can reach conduct beyond denial of access, but the fact that an act affects or humiliates a Scheduled Caste person does not by itself answer whether Section 7(1)(d) is attracted. The provision requires the insult to be “on the ground of ‘untouchability’”.

How has the Supreme Court interpreted Article 17?

The Supreme Court addressed the scope of Article 17 in *Sukanya Shantha v Union of India* (2024), while striking down caste-discriminatory provisions in prison manuals and reviewing its earlier Article 17 jurisprudence.

The court described untouchability as connected to the caste system and its interconnected notions of “purity and pollution”. These ideas, it said, have been used to reinforce caste hierarchy and influence whom people associate with and how they treat one another. Article 17 rejects such notions.

The judgment also explains why the absence of a definition does not necessarily confine the scope of Article 17. It noted that even a broadly worded definition could become restrictive because discrimination can manifest itself through the “manifold complexities” of social life. Article 17 must therefore be capable of reaching untouchability in its

different forms and manifestations.

The court then stated the principle directly: “There cannot be any stigma attached to the existence, touch or presence of any person.”

The court’s reasoning is therefore not confined to familiar forms of exclusion. It also addresses the underlying caste idea of pollution: discriminatory treatment based on a person’s touch or presence.

What has the court said about such practices?

In *Surya Narayan Choudhary v State of Rajasthan* (1988), the Rajasthan High Court considered discrimination against Dalit devotees at the public Shrinathji temple in Nathdwara.

The court was told that Dalit devotees were permitted to enter only after undergoing a process of purification.

Crucially, the High Court held that Dalit devotees could not be subjected to an additional condition for temple entry that did not apply to other devotees, and specifically directed that the reported purification practice be discontinued, holding it discriminatory and violative of Articles 14, 15 and 17.

At Nathdwara, purification was imposed on Dalit devotees before they could enter a temple on equal terms. At Haldwani, the ritual occurred after Mr. Kharge had already used the venue, and

the reason for it is disputed. The *Surya Narayan Choudhary* case therefore does not decide the present controversy; it establishes the narrower proposition that caste-specific ritual purification imposed on Dalits as a condition of equal access can violate Article 17.

Where is the legal boundary?

Article 17 and the Protection of Civil Rights Act must also be distinguished from the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, which creates separate criminal offences with their own ingredients.

Section 3(1)(r), for example, deals with intentionally insulting or intimidating an SC/ST member with intent to humiliate them in a place within public view, when committed by a person who is not an SC or ST. In *Hitesh Verma v State of Uttarakhand* (2020), the Supreme Court said that not every insult to an SC/ST person attracts the provision: the insult or intimidation must be connected to the victim belonging to the protected community. More recently, in *Gunjan @ Girija Kumari v State* (NCT of Delhi) (2026), the Supreme Court reiterated that “public view” is an essential requirement for the offence.

What would establish untouchability?

If evidence were to show that the venue was regarded as requiring cleansing because caste-based notions of pollution were attached to Mr. Kharge’s touch or presence, the reasoning in *Sukanya Shantha* case and the caste-specific purification considered in *Surya Narayan Choudhary* case would become directly relevant. If, on the other hand, the ritual was undertaken for reasons unconnected with caste, including the reasons cited by the organisers, its timing after Mr. Kharge’s rally would not by itself establish untouchability.

The word *shuddhikaran* cannot answer that question. The legal issue is the connection, if any, between the ritual and caste-based notions of pollution. (*Sahil Hussain Choudhury is an advocate and Constitutional law researcher from Assam*)

THE GIST

Article 17 abolishes untouchability in all forms, while the Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955 penalises its practice, including insults based on untouchability.

The Supreme Court has linked untouchability to caste-based notions of ‘purity and pollution’, holding that Article 17 can address different forms of discriminatory treatment based on a person’s touch or presence.

Whether the Haldwani ritual amounts to untouchability would depend on evidence of a caste-based connection; the word ‘*shuddhikaran*’ or the ritual’s timing alone would not establish it.

What does Thailand’s new amnesty Act cover?

Who would benefit from the new Act? What are the shortcomings of the amnesty push?

Vighnesh P. Venkitesh

The story so far:

Thailand’s Peaceful Society Promotion Act, an amnesty initiative passed by lawmakers in July, came into effect on August 24, as the government under Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul seeks reconciliation with a large share of the population still leaning towards populist former leader Thaksin Shinawatra, a key figure at the centre of the country’s political turmoil.

What are the provisions of the new Act?

The Act seeks to grant amnesty to those convicted over protests or for “expressions motivated by political conflicts” from January 1, 2005, to July 16, 2025, except for offences involving corruption, lese majeste violations,

murder or causing serious injuries, and those against private entities on a case-by-case basis.

The Act has listed more than 40 categories of offences eligible for amnesty, including severe charges such as sedition, rebellion, cybercrimes and emergency violations.

The Act calls for the setting up of a committee, the “peaceful society promotion committee”, led by the Prime Minister or his deputy within a month to determine who qualifies for amnesty. The panel will have representatives from Parliament, human rights experts, and civil society organisation members.

In addition to granting release for current prisoners, the committee can also close investigations and prosecutions, dismiss pending court cases, and clear criminal records of those eligible for the amnesty. Government officials have said that the panel will review all political

cases recorded between 2005 and 2025 under the Act.

Who would benefit from the new Act?

The Thai Lawyers for Human Rights says that more than 5,000 individuals have been prosecuted for political conflicts since the 2006 coup, with a third of these happening after 2020, with around 300 of those involved being under the age of 18.

It said that, as of July this year, around 54 people remained in prison over political activities, but only around 10 of them would be eligible for amnesty since the others have Article 112 charges against them.

Other than those in prison, the Act would also clear the records of thousands with charges. This includes members of pro-Shinawatra bodies and anti-monarchy outfits as well as the royalists who took part in the ‘yellow shirt’ protests in 2006 that led to the coup and subsequent

ouster of Mr. Shinawatra and years of instability.

The current Bhumjaithai Party-led government, which came to power after a snap election following a short term as a minority government, is on thin ice, having to manage strong voices from multiple political alignments in the country, and the sweeping amnesty provisions, which can be interpreted for the pro-democracy outfits as well as the royalists simultaneously, is a strategic move to secure support.

What are the shortcomings of the amnesty push?

While the new Act will erase politically motivated criminal records for thousands of people, several organisations have questioned the exclusion of lese majeste provisions from its ambit. The draconian Article 112, critics say, has been used to silence dissent by governments, including the royalists and the populists, with even juveniles being charged and awaiting trial for defaming the King and senior officials of the royalty.

While the Act has listed sedition and rebellion as charges eligible for amnesty consideration, Section 112 remained non-negotiable during lawmakers’ deliberation. A minority faction of independent Senators had moved during the drafting period of the legislation to introduce a clause to grant amnesty for

Section 112 convicts under 18 years of age at the time of the offense, but this was set aside in a 126 to 15 vote.

Critics say that the new Act also has a provision explicitly stipulating that even the existing special rehabilitation and judicial diversion plans for minors cannot be applied to any youth facing a Section 112 charge. This ensures that the law serves as a “blunt instrument of absolute exclusion, stripping young pro-democracy activists of the legal protections normally afforded to children under both domestic and international human rights frameworks”, 112watch, a Thai organisation, said.

The legislation shows that political reconciliation in Thailand is “selective, conditional, and reserved only for favoured factions”, the organisation said in a statement condemning its clearance. “Excluding Article 112 – a provision historically used as a political weapon to suppress dissent – does not foster national harmony; it deepens societal wounds and institutionalises state impunity”, it said.

The group has also flagged the insertion of offences related to election fraud into the scope of amnesty under the Act, which could potentially clear individuals involved in collusion during senatorial elections, which is not related to the political expression that the government seeks to look beyond.

CACHE

India’s data centre boom is colliding with its climate reality

India’s data centre expansion is attracting billions in investment, but rising electricity and water demand, transmission bottlenecks, heat generation are straining already stressed resources; a national framework with enforceable standards is needed to manage these costs and protect consumers

Soumya Sarkar

India is in the middle of a data centre gold rush. Global tech giants – Google, Meta, Amazon, Microsoft – have committed billions to build facilities across the country. The government estimates that data centres will drive nearly \$200 billion in investment over the coming decade.

Many States in the country are competing fiercely for a piece of the pie. Maharashtra wants to be the data centre capital of the country. Telangana has declared data centres as “essential services.” Karnataka is reviewing its policy to attract more. Rajasthan is offering tax exemptions and cheap land. All eyes are on the opportunity, but none on the cost.

Data centre capacity in India has nearly tripled from 520 megawatts in 2020 to nearly 1.5 gigawatts today. By 2030, it is projected to hit 6.5 GW, which is a fourfold expansion in just four years. Electricity demand from these facilities is expected to rise from about 13 terawatt-hours (TWh) in 2024 to roughly 57 TWh by 2030. The Union Ministry of Power estimates that artificial intelligence alone will add 26.3 gigawatts of new demand by 2031-32.

No policy document, at the Central or State level, has assessed what guaranteed power costs the grid that is already strained under 45°C heat, or where the water will come from for cooling, or what the thermal load from thousands of servers will do to regions already teetering on dangerously high temperatures.

The resource reality

A 100 MW data centre consumes about 2 million litres of water daily. That is equivalent to the daily use of roughly 6,500 households. India’s data centres consumed an estimated 150 billion litres of water in 2024-25. By 2030, that figure is projected to more than double to 358 billion litres annually.

The water use matters because data centres are clustering in India’s most water-stressed regions. Rajasthan extracts 147.11% of its annual groundwater recharge, the second highest rate in the country. Several groundwater assessment units in Maharashtra are classified as semi-critical. Telangana’s Irrigation Minister confirmed in May 2026 that 16 districts were under groundwater stress. Hyderabad’s surface water supply dropped 20% during the summer of 2024 due to poor monsoon recharge, forcing the water board to ration supply. Mumbai’s reservoirs stood at just 44.5% of capacity in March 2026.

The water these facilities consume is not accounted for in any State policy. None of the policies require public disclosure of daily water consumption. None require a hydrogeological assessment before approval. None mandate that water sourcing must not compete with agriculture or municipal supply.

The electricity situation is equally concerning. India’s power grid is already straining under record demand. Maharashtra’s peak power demand hit 27,230 MW in April 2026, the highest ever handled by the State utility. Two-year waits for 220 kV grid interconnections across the country are already lengthening project timelines.

Transmission constraints are also



GETTY IMAGES

becoming a critical bottleneck. India curtailed 300 GW-hours of renewable energy in the first quarter of 2026 alone, simply because the grid could not carry it, according to an analysis of Central Electricity Authority data by Ember Energy, a specialised consultancy. Over the past five years, India has met only about 80% of its annual transmission targets. One in four major transmission schemes is running a year or more behind schedule. As a result, 20 GW of renewable energy capacity faces connectivity delays of more than four months.

Rajasthan and Gujarat, which house the bulk of India’s utility-scale solar and wind, face the longest queues at pooling stations. The problem has become structural in the country. Solar projects are being built faster than the wires to carry their power. This matters because data centres need reliable, uninterrupted electricity. If renewable energy cannot reach them, the power will come from coal, adding to the burden of carbon emissions that India is trying to curtail.

The heat they generate

Data centres do not just consume power and water. They also generate heat. And that heat makes the places around them hotter. A March 2026 study from the University of Cambridge, analysing 20 years of NASA satellite data, found that data centres raise land surface temperatures by an average of 2°C within a 10 km radius, with extreme cases reaching 9.1°C. The study estimates that approximately 340 million people globally live within these affected zones.

This is not a distant problem. Mumbai’s land surface temperature has already risen from 40.9°C in 2003 to 47.3°C in 2023, an increase driven largely by urbanisation and heat-trapping infrastructure. Hyderabad’s urban heat island intensity ranges from 5.74°C to

6.82°C, even as its urban area doubled between 2001 and 2020. The city recorded temperatures above 43°C in the summer of 2024.

The Cambridge finding creates a feedback loop. Data centres generate heat. That heat raises ambient temperatures. Higher ambient temperatures increase cooling demand. Increased cooling demand raises electricity consumption. Higher electricity consumption, unless fully renewable, increases emissions. And those emissions contribute to the very climate change that is making India hotter in the first place.

The governance gap

The data centre policies of various States offer generous incentives in the form of electricity duty exemptions, transmission charge waivers, stamp duty relief, and fast-track clearances. But they impose virtually no conditions. None of the major State policies require a grid impact assessment before commissioning. None require mandatory renewable energy sourcing. None require thermal load assessment for surrounding communities.

Telangana’s policy is particularly revealing. It classifies data centres as “essential services,” guaranteeing them uninterrupted power even during shortages. In a State where 16 districts face groundwater stress and temperatures have reached 47°C, this is a policy choice with direct consequences.

Maharashtra’s policy originally required 100% renewable energy for core operations. In June 2026, the State reduced that requirement to 51%, a dilution framed as improving project viability.

Gujarat’s new Data Centre Policy 2026-29 mandates at least 51% green energy sourcing. Karnataka’s IT minister told the State Assembly in March 2026

that the State was reviewing its policy over water and energy concerns. Tamil Nadu has linked incentives to renewable compliance. But these are exceptions, not the norm. And even where mandates exist, enforcement and verification remain weak.

“There is a risk that a significant part of the associated infrastructure cost could eventually be socialised,” said Vibhuti Garg, Director, South Asia at the Institute for Energy Economics and Financial Analysis (IEEFA), a think tank. “Where broader grid infrastructure is required, government support or appropriate financing mechanisms could help ensure that the cost is not simply transferred to consumers through higher electricity tariffs.”

“Governments should introduce phased power and water use standards with enforceable benchmarks,” said Prateek Aggarwal, Senior Programme Lead at Council on Energy, Environment and Water, a Delhi-based think tank. “A national AI Energy Star rating would let buyers and regulators compare how energy-efficient a facility or model actually is.”

What needs to change

India’s generation pipeline can absorb the additional demand from data centres. The Union Ministry of Power says capacity is not the constraint. The constraint is market design and transmission infrastructure.

Aggarwal argued that “India needs climate-intelligent power markets that price grid services separately, where short-term markets pay for ramping, storage, and demand response.” Ember’s analysis points to another near-term solution in the form of battery storage at renewable pooling stations. Roughly 3-4 GW of two-hour storage could have absorbed most of the curtailed generation in early 2026, according to its calculations. The technical pieces are in place but the gap is regulatory and commercial.

IEEFA has suggested that coastal locations offer advantages such as proximity to near-shore wind and solar, and access to seawater for cooling without desalination. But for now, most data centres are clustering around existing tech hubs of Mumbai, Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and the National Capital Region. These are precisely the places where water and grid stress are already most acute.

A national sustainability framework would help. It would establish minimum standards for renewable energy sourcing, water consumption disclosure, grid impact assessment, and thermal load evaluation. It would create a common set of expectations for investors and a common set of protections for consumers. It would also recognise that environmental constraints are economic constraints, and that ignoring them only creates larger costs later.

Data centres are not optional. They are critical infrastructure for India’s digital future. The question is not whether India should build them. The data centres will be built. It remains to be seen whether they will be built in a way that protects India’s water, power grid and climate, or in a way that leaves future generations to pay the bill. (Soumya Sarkar is an independent journalist based in New Delhi and Kolkata)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the difference between “resume” and “biodata”? (Mootha Sarva Rayudu, Kakinada)

It is difficult to point out the difference between the two. In the Indian context, I guess one could say that there is no difference between them. A “bio-data” is a resume. A native speaker, on the other hand, may not understand what you mean by “bio-data”. The word does not exist in most native varieties of English. The words commonly used by native speakers are CV (curriculum vitae) and resume. In India, however, the word ‘bio-data’ is much more common than the other two.

Is ‘juggernaut’ derived from Lord Jagannath? (S. Bakthavathsalan, Gurgaon, Haryana)

Yes, Lord Jagannath of Puri has given us the word “juggernaut”. As you probably know, Lord Jagannath and his consort are usually placed on huge chariots and taken out in procession every year. Lots of people from various parts of the country come to see and participate in this event. Many people line up as volunteers to pull the heavy chariot. Whenever you have a huge crowd, accidents are very commonplace; they are just waiting to happen. There have been several reported cases of people accidentally falling and being crushed by the huge wheels of Lord Jagannath’s chariot. A person who was a witness to such accidents was a Franciscan missionary named Friar Odoric. He visited India in the 14th Century and wrote about his visit to Puri in a journal, which he published in Europe later on. In his journal, Odoric wrote in detail about the huge chariot of Jagannath and how the devotees threw themselves at the chariot wheels, allowing themselves to be crushed. According to Odoric, the people were offering themselves as a sacrifice to the Lord! The European readers were shocked and horrified when they read this, and began to associate the word “juggernaut” with a huge object that is out of control. The Friar’s story of the human sacrifice spread throughout Europe and by the 19th Century “juggernaut” began to be associated with a massive object that destroyed everything in its path. It was seen as a destructive force. It is interesting to note that “trains”, “tanks”, and even “automobiles”, when they were first introduced, were referred to as “juggernauts”! The word has a negative connotation in English. Here are a few examples.

Sandeep is very naive. He thinks it is possible to compete with the juggernauts of the industry.

Believe it or not, the skinny man standing over there is a political juggernaut.

What is the meaning of “cut off one’s nose to spite one face”? (Pranjal Kishore Sharmah, Jorhat, Assam)

This is one of those expressions that has been around for quite some time. If you wanted to get even with someone, or hurt the feelings of that person, would you do it by cutting off your nose? Would that be a sensible thing to do? It wouldn’t, would it? That’s what the expression ‘cut off one’s nose to spite one’s face’ means. It means harming oneself, perhaps much more than the person one is trying to hurt.

Harish loves to play tennis, but he refused to play with Suresh because he doesn’t like him. He was cutting off his nose to spite his face.”
Published in The Hindu on October 30, 2001

Word of the day

Lacuna:
a blank gap or missing part

Synonyms: shortage, lack, deficiency, paucity, absence, scarcity

Usage: *There is a lacuna in the report that needs to be addressed.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/lacuna
International Phonetic Alphabet: /ləkju:nə/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

THE DAILY QUIZ

On September 2, 1946, an interim government headed by Jawaharlal Nehru began functioning as British India took its first major step towards the transfer of power

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1
Which British constitutional initiative provided the framework for the formation of the interim government?

QUESTION 2
Who served as Commander-in-Chief of India while the interim government was in operation?

QUESTION 3
On what date did the Muslim League join the interim government?

QUESTION 4
Through what electoral mechanism were members of the Constituent Assembly, from which the interim government was formed, chosen?

QUESTION 5
On what date did the interim government cease to exist, and what major constitutional event brought its tenure to an end?



Visual Question:
Identify these members of the interim government from left to right. SELECTED WORKS OF JAWAHARLAL NEHRU, SECOND SERIES, VOL. 1, PP. 160–161

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. Who was the first Indian to win the Magsaysay Award as early as 1958? **Ans: Vinoba Bhave**
2. Who won the award in 1965 for public service? What was the title that he was known by? **Ans: Jayaprakash Narayan; Lok Nayak**
3. Name the Indian who won the award in 1974. Name the last and most prominent film featuring her? **Ans: M.S. Subbulakshmi. Meera**
4. Another award winner in 2005, this person was born into a family that had two distinguished Nobel laureates. She served as a leading doctor and director of the Cancer Institute in Chennai. **Ans: V. Shanta**
5. A former IAS officer, this awardee led major campaigns, the most prominent of which was the National Campaign for the People’s Right to Information, which culminated in the Right to Information Act being passed. **Ans: Aruna Roy**
Visual: Identify this awardee. Cited for “guiding the people of [Andhra Pradesh] to end the scourge of child labour and send all of their children to school”. **Ans: Shantha Sinha**
Early Birds: Siddhartha Viswanathan | Piyalí Tulí | Tamal Biswas | Sunil Madhavan | Lalchand Bhutani

INBRIEF



Inara Foods, Kalimark tie up to expand snack distribution

Inara Foods, an SPV of Whiteleaf Ventures Pvt. Ltd. and Dubai-based Plus Investments LLC of the Al Ghurair Group, has announced a distribution partnership with the Kalimark Group, expanding the reach of former's portfolio of snack products, including chikkis, flavoured peanuts, chips, mixtures and other offerings, to nearly one lakh retail outlets across Tamil Nadu through Kalimark's extensive distribution network. Nawabzada Mohammed Asif Ali, Chairman of Whiteleaf Ventures, said the company aims to establish Inara Foods as a leading snack brand across Tamil Nadu, with plans to expand its presence across India in the future.

IRDAI kick starts consultation for Public Insurance Registry

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) released a consultation paper for the Public Insurance Registry on Tuesday describing the PIR it is proposing as a population-scale, interoperable and non-exclusionary digital public infrastructure (DPI). The objectives of the PIR are to facilitate growth and inclusion, building trust and transparency, and promoting affordability and financial sustainability. It is significant step towards building a more connected, transparent, efficient and resilient insurance ecosystem, with trusted information serving as a foundation for better protection, innovation and public value, the regulator said. The proposal, is in line with the objectives of the Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha Act, 2025, draws inspiration from the success and lessons from DPIs in other sectors of Indian economy. It is intended to enable technology, governance and market participation to work together towards wider and deeper financial resilience.

GST revenue grows 14.8% in Aug. to nearly ₹2 lakh crore

Official data show revenue from imports grew 29%, whereas revenue from domestic transactions grew in the single digits; net collections grew a relatively lower 8.3% on higher refunds given out

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Gross Goods and Services Tax (GST) collections grew nearly 15% to about ₹2 lakh crore in August, official data released on Tuesday showed. Net collections, however, grew a relatively lower 8.3% on higher refunds being given out.

The Gross GST revenue stood at ₹1,99,853 crore in August 2026, reflecting the business activity of July.

The data also shows that the collections for August last year were revised downward from the originally reported ₹1.86 lakh crore to ₹1.74 lakh crore. As a result, the growth in gross collections in July 2026 now stands at 14.8%.

Had the July 2025 figure not been revised, growth



The sharp 72.6% surge in domestic refunds driven by inverted duty structures signals an imbalance, says an analyst. GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

in gross GST collections in August 2026 would have been 7%.

Within the data, tax analysts have also pointed out the continued robust growth in revenues from imports as opposed to the slower growth in revenue from domestic transactions.

“The quality of collections warrants closer attention,” Manoj Mishra, Partner and Tax Controversy Management Leader at Grant Thornton Bharat said. “While gross GST revenue expanded by 14.8% year-on-year, domestic collections grew 9.3%, whereas import-related GST

surged 29%, indicating that trade-linked activity continues to make a disproportionately higher contribution to revenue buoyancy.”

They also pointed out that the sharp increase in refunds, which grew nearly 68% overall in August 2026, also pointed to structural issues that the GST Council should take note of in its next meeting scheduled on September 12.

“The sharp 72.6% surge in domestic refunds, driven by inverted duty structures, signals a structural imbalance that warrants urgent redressal,” Vivek Jalan, Partner at Tax Connect Advisory Services LLP said. “The Hon’ble GST Council may address these anomalies in its forthcoming meeting to ensure that the tax framework supports competitiveness.”

LPG consumption declines 16% in Aug.

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI



Consumption of LPG in August slipped to 2.424 MMT

India's LPG consumption declined about 16.2% in August from a year earlier, according to provisional government data, as growing shift toward piped natural gas (PNG) weighed on demand for cooking fuel.

Meanwhile, petrol and diesel consumption rose 7.9% and 6.5%, respectively, year-on-year (YoY) in August. The increase in diesel demand was driven by greater use of irrigation equipment amid below-normal monsoon, while higher mobility and transportation needs also supported fuel consumption.

Consumption of LPG in August slipped to 2.424 million metric tonnes (MMT), according to provisional government data.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Prashant Vashisht, Senior V-P at ICRA, said persistent concerns over the availability of the bottled hydrocarbon gas coincided with

a sharp rise in PNG connections, including among industrial consumers.

“Some industrial LPG consumers shifted to PNG and found the supply was reliable as [constant] availability-related issues persist for LPG,” he said, attributing the increase to a rise in industrial PNG consumers.

Data from the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board showed PNG connections rose 36% between April and June this year to 4.61 lakh, supported by “strong growth” across segments.

India's current account deficit widens to \$4.2 bn in Q1 FY27

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

India's current account deficit (CAD) widened to \$4.2 billion, or 0.5% of GDP, in the first quarter of 2026-27, compared with \$3.4 billion, or 0.4% of GDP, in the year-ago period, according to preliminary data released by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Tuesday.

The widening deficit

was primarily driven by a higher merchandise trade gap, which increased to \$86.1 billion in Q1 FY27 from \$68.9 billion in the corresponding quarter of 2025-26.

However, stronger services earnings and higher remittance receipts provided some cushion. Net services receipts rose to \$51.6 billion during the quarter from \$47.9 billion a year earlier. Services exports re-

However, stronger services earnings and higher remittance receipts provided some cushion

corded year-on-year growth across major segments, including computer services, other business services and transportation services.

The net outgo under the primary income account

declined to \$10.5 billion in Q1 FY27 from \$13.3 billion in the year-ago quarter, mainly reflecting lower investment income payments, the RBI said.

Personal transfer receipts under the secondary income account, largely comprising remittances from Indians employed overseas, increased sharply to \$42.9 billion from \$33.2 billion a year earlier.

On the financial ac-

count, net foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows rose to \$6.1 billion in Q1 FY27 from \$5.2 billion in Q1 FY26.

Foreign portfolio investment (FPI), however, recorded a net outflow of \$9.6 billion during the quarter, reversing a net inflow of \$1.6 billion in the corresponding period last year. Net inflows into non-resident deposits stood at \$2.8 billion, lower than the

\$3.6 billion recorded in Q1 FY26. Net inflows under external commercial borrowings (ECBs) also moderated to \$3.3 billion from \$4.4 billion a year earlier.

India's foreign exchange reserves declined by \$8.1 billion on a balance-of-payments basis during Q1 FY27, compared with an accretion of \$4.5 billion in the same quarter of the previous year, according to the RBI.

PV wholesales surge in Aug. as Maruti, Tata, M&M drive double-digit growth

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

India's passenger vehicle (PV) market maintained a strong growth trajectory in August with major automakers reporting robust year-on-year (YoY) gains amid sustained local demand. Wholesales were estimated at about 4.5 lakh units for the month, said senior industry officials.

Market leader Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. led the market with total wholesales of 2,19,220 units, up 21.3%. Domestic wholesales jumped 34.3%, offsetting a 7% dip in exports to 33,844 units as shipments were affected by the West Asia conflict. Sales to other OEMs fell 48% to 5,298.



Maruti Suzuki cars are seen parked inside the company factory at Manesar.

Maruti said it crossed the one-million-unit mark in the first five months of FY27 on higher output and strong demand.

“We have a booking backlog of 1.8 lakh vehicles. Our SUV share in our entire portfolio has risen to 36% from 12% five years

ago,” said Partho Banerjee, senior executive officer, sales and marketing, Maruti Suzuki India.

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd. posted a 56% rise in total wholesales to 67,753 units.

Mahindra & Mahindra reported overall auto sales of 1,07,648 units, including exports, a 42% increase.

“Demand continues to be strong across our portfolio, with the updated Scorpio-N and BE 6 SPORTEQ receiving strong market response from customers,” said Velusamy R., president, automotive business, M&M.

Hyundai Motor India Ltd. (HMIL) wholesales of 65,796 units showed an 8.8% growth. Domestic

sales rose 23.6% to 54,396 while exports slid to 11,400 from more than 16,000 a year earlier on West Asia issue.

“We are optimistic that export demand will continue to be strong in the coming months as the geopolitical situation improves,” said Tarun Garg, MD & CEO, HMIL.

Kia India recorded one of the strongest growth rates among major PV makers with dispatches rising 48% to 29,042 units.

JSW MG Motor India also sustained growth momentum with a 14% rise in sales to 7,508 units. It said demand was strong across both internal combustion engine and new energy vehicle (NEV) portfolios.

Premium offering



Machine made: A Sharpa robot makes a Blizzard ice cream for a customer at a Dairy Queen store in Shanghai on Tuesday. AFP

FII tax cuts same as Centre funding their under-performance

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Dwindling stock market returns in Indian indices, especially for foreign institutional investors (FIIs) should not determine tax policy changes, said Harendra Kumar, MD-CEO, Elara Capital

Speaking to *The Hindu*, he said pushing for tax cuts for FIIs is “asking the government to fund their under-performance”.

“The FII amount is over the cost and rupee depreciation. They should make money post-tax. This problem was not there two years ago as they were



Harendra Kumar

making serious money,” he said, asking why they had not raised the issue two years ago when they were making money. He added it was not even international investors but hedge funds and high frequency traders complaining about taxation in India.

UPI transaction volumes touch an all-time high of 24.51 billion in August

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Homegrown Unified Payments Interface (UPI) processed a record 24.51 billion transactions worth ₹29.8 lakh crore in August, primarily fuelled by Raksha Bandhan, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI).

The UPI transactions in value terms were ₹29.8 lakh crore, near a record high of ₹29.9 lakh crore in May and July 2026.

As per the data released on Tuesday, UPI transactions in volume terms touched a record of 24.51 billion in August, much higher than 23.66 billion in

the previous month.

The volume was 22.72 billion in June and 23.2 billion in May of this year.

The value of transactions was ₹29.82 lakh crore in August, up from ₹24.85 lakh crore in the same month a year ago, registering 20% annual growth.

At the same time, UPI volume rose by 22% on an annual basis to 24.51 billion in August as against 19.63 billion in the same month last year, according to NPCI data.

NPCI, an initiative of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Indian Banks' Association, is an umbrella organisation for operating retail payments and settlement systems in India

(IBA). It runs the UPI used for real-time payments between peers or at merchants' end while making purchases.

Festive activity boost

The volume growth in August was further bolstered by festive activity such as Raksha Bandhan, which naturally drove a surge in everyday peer-to-peer (P2P) transfers and small-ticket gifting, and consistent aggregate transaction value with an increase in volume over the past three months underscores the expanding reach and depth of the UPI ecosystem, Cashfree Payments co-founder Rejeev Datta said. Looking ahead, he

said, the upcoming festive season presents an exciting growth frontier.

As the festive season approaches and new use cases such as credit on UPI start to mature, continued investment in resilient, intelligent infrastructure will be key to sustaining India's leadership in digital payments, Network People Services Technologies (NPST) co-founder and CEO Deepak Chand Thakur said.

UPI now is accepted in 11 countries, with Uzbekistan being the latest entry. Other countries accepting UPI are Singapore, UAE, France, Mauritius, Nepal, Bhutan, Qatar, Sri Lanka, Cambodia, and Greece.

CIE scheme to boost local making, cut import dependence

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Construction and Infrastructure Equipment (CIE) scheme announced in Union Budget 2026-27 will boost local manufacturing, boost local supply chain and cut excessive dependence on imports, Union Heavy Industries Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy said at an event here.

The scheme's modalities are yet to be finalised. While Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in her Budget speech on February 1 announced a scheme at an estimated ₹200 crore, media reports

suggest the Centre is considering a much broader programme with an incentive outlay of ₹11,500 crore over seven years.

The need to encourage greater participation of micro, small and medium enterprises in the construction equipment value chain was also underlined by the Minister.

India is the world's third-largest construction equipment market after China and the U.S. The industry, valued at about ₹97,500 crore in 2024-25, provides direct employment to about 10 lakh and is likely to touch ₹2.28 lakh crore by 2029-30.

France targets Shein and Temu with fast fashion fees



Green fee: A customer holds shopping bags with a logo of fast-fashion retailer Shein in Paris, France. REUTERS

Reuters
PARIS

France started imposing fees on the extreme end of fast fashion on Tuesday to try to curb a surge in sales of cheap clothing sold by e-commerce sites including Shein and Temu.

The charges - part of a fast-fashion law passed in June that aimsto address environmental concerns from overproduction -range from €0.25 (30 U.S. cents) for a pair of boxer shorts or socks to €12 (\$14) for a coat, with the amount capped at 50% of the product's pre-tax sales price.

“These platforms are false champions of consumer purchasing power. They sell at low prices, yet their products often fail to meet standards and lack durability,” Commerce Minister Serge Papin told local newspaper Ouest France.

The fee adds to Shein's difficulties as the end of duty-free access for cheap e-commerce parcels in the European Union and the U.S. caused the company's valuation to plunge ahead of its stock market debut in Hong Kong on Tuesday.

Push prices up: Neither Shein nor Temu responded to requests for comment on the fees. Shein's spokesperson in France, Quentin Ruff at, has previously said the fast-fashion charges would hurt customers by pushing prices up.

China's commerce ministry has described the French law as discriminatory and a trade barrier, saying it could be violating WTO principles.

Fee based on various factors The French fees, set to increase further from 2030, are calculated using a formula that takes into account the number of products available under a brand, their prices and irreparability.

France is the first EU country to penalise retailers based on the number of items they offer on their website. Shein's product selection included more than 2 million items as of March 31 this year, with 4,700 new apparel styles each day, according to its prospectus.

European retailers, such as Inditex's Zara and H&M, which offer a smaller range of products on their websites, are not expected to be impacted, according to a briefing by officials on Monday.

Sorting waste, recycling Under the EU textile Extended Producer Responsibility directive, all member states must introduce fees by April 17, 2028 that are collected from producers by an association to fund sorting waste and recycling of discarded clothing.

In France's case, the association, Refashion, will manage collection of the new charges and determine who is liable to pay them.

Some other member states have also already set up textile EPR associations, including the Netherlands.

However its body, Stichting UPV Textiel, will collect fees from retailers based on the volume of clothing they sell in the country, not the size of their range, according to its website.

Reuters
HOUSTON,

An unprecedented deal for the U.S. to gain access to a fifth of Venezuela's oil reserves -and the central role a Venezuelan businessman will play - is prompting questions and hesitation from some oil companies evaluating potential investments in the country, sources familiar with the situation told *Reuters*.

A White House fact sheet released late on Monday outlined an arrangement under which private oil firm North American BlueEnergy Partners (NABEP) would receive a 100-year lease for 17 oilfields in Venezuela holding some 65 billion barrels of oil reserves. The U.S. will take a 35% equity stake in the cor-

porate parent company, receive a guaranteed 20% of the oil production and hold a right-of-first-refusal to purchase all of the remaining output.

Under a cloud NABEP is controlled by Venezuelan businessman Alejandro Betancourt, who has been the subject of investigations by U.S. and European authorities following past dealings with the Venezuelan government, although he was never charged. He has previously denied allegations against him.

“Oil majors and large foreign companies negotiating contract migrations want to make sure they will not be seated at the same table with Betancourt,” said a person involved in

Texas’ halt on powering data centres shows U.S. view of ‘ghost’ demand

Electricity requests from large power users exceed 700 GW across parts of U.S., *Reuters* review finds; Texas data centre, large energy user requests soar from about 48 GW in 2023 to more than 474 GW currently; Pennsylvania says only 20 of more than 100 proposed data centres sought permits

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters

Data centres have requested roughly as much electricity across the middle swath of the United States (U.S.) as it takes to power every home in the country, but much of that demand may be an illusion.

In an attempt to find out what is real, Texas recently became the first major data centre hub to freeze new grid connections for the facilities and investigate their plans. Other U.S. states are taking similar steps to fix the intensifying problem that is vexing regulators and politicians nationwide.

A *Reuters* review of utility and grid data found that electricity requests from very large power users, mostly data centres, exceed 700 gigawatts – or more than 10 times industry estimates of current U.S. data centre power use – across portions of the Midwest, Mid-Atlantic and the South. Consumer advocates and regulators have cautioned that many requests are likely to be duplicative, or made by companies without the funds or expertise to see the projects through, threatening to stymie grid planning that is crucial to keeping the lights on.

Some of those warnings are now being validated,



Powering up: The steel frame of data centers under construction at Texas, U.S. REUTERS

with major utilities cutting their data centre demand figures once financial guardrails, like requiring upfront payments, are put in place.

The uncertainty is leading data centre hot spots like Texas, Pennsylvania and Ohio to enact rules to filter out projects that could drive up prices and provoke political backlash without ever even getting built. “When you don’t know what is real, you really don’t know how to build the infrastructure for it,” Texas Public Utility Commission Chairman Thomas Gleeson said at an industry conference in March.

Ghost demand As Big Tech’s planned AI data centre spending tops \$700 billion this year, com-



When states and utilities have taken a closer look at data centre electricity projects, however, and enacted requirements like large upfront deposits, chunks of the demand can fall away

panies and landowners with access to power or grid connections have rushed to cash in on the boom by securing electricity supplies needed to run those facilities.

Since 2023, requests from data centres and other large energy users to connect to the Texas grid have soared from about 48 gigawatts to more than 474 gigawatts, according to

documents from grid operator ERCOT and Governor Greg Abbott, making it the fastest-growing region for AI and cloud server warehouses in the world by some measures.

Outside of Texas, data centre electricity demand requests in 10 of the biggest U.S. utilities in the Midwest, Mid-Atlantic and U.S. South, including AEP Ohio, Southern Co and PPL, have reached about 270 gigawatts, according to a review of the latest utility quarterly earnings calls with investors.

No set standard There is no set standard for how utilities report requests for electricity from data centres, with some disclosing only projects that have signed contracts

Japan faces policy reckoning on rate increase

Reuters
ASHEVILLE, NORTH CAROLINA



Tough call: For dovish PM Sanae Takaichi, the starkest message may have been Bessent's calling an end to Abenomics, AFP

While the BOJ was already widely expected to lift rates in September as inflation pressures grew, Bessent's comments effectively lock the bank into doing so and put pressure on it to step up hikes going forward.

“The July joint intervention was a message from

months may be too slow.”

Weak yen, inflation A weak yen has pushed up import prices and broader inflation, causing headaches for Japanese policymakers by increasing households’ cost of living.

For Washington, too-slow BOJ rate hikes and loose fiscal policy could trigger a selloff in the yen and Japanese government bonds, potentially upending financial markets with spillovers to U.S. Treasury yields - something it wants to avoid. Markets are focusing on what BOJ chief Ueda could say after attending the two-day G20 finance leaders’ meeting in Asheville, North Carolina, concluding on Tuesday. A U.S. Treasury official told Japanese public broadcaster NHK that Bessent had met

Ueda on Sunday and called for the need for rate hikes.

Economics, politics Even without U.S. pressure, the BOJ's recent hawkish communication suggests it is gearing up for a near-term rate hike on broadening inflationary pressure. “Consumer inflation will likely accelerate given all the pressure coming from producer prices. If so, the BOJ must act,” said a source familiar with its thinking.

With a September rate hike already baked in, however, the BOJ may need to pledge speedier increases to alleviate downward pressure on the yen.

“Japan's real interest rates are clearly too low,” said Japan's former top currency diplomat Naoyuki Shinohara. “One or two

more hikes won't be enough to reverse the yen's downtrend.”

Oxford Economics said it now expects the BOJ to raise rates in September and December this year, followed by a third hike in April 2027, a faster pace than initially expected.

“The economic and political cost of disappointing markets and the U.S. has become too big for the BOJ and the government to ignore,” Shigeto Nagai, head of Japan economics at Oxford Economics, said.

For dovish PM Sanae Takaichi, the starkest message may have been Bessent's calling an end to Abenomics, a mix of massive monetary stimulus, big spending and a growth strategy deployed in 2013 to end prolonged deflation.

Trump’s oil deal with Venezuela said to raise serious red flags



Tough cookie: Oil platforms and pumpjacks at Lake Maracaibo in Cabimas, Venezuela. REUTERS

preparations for an event where energy contracts are expected to be signed this week.

NABEP, which produces around 1,70,000 barrels of oil a day, did not imme-

diately respond to a request for comment for this story. In an emailed company statement after the White House released details of the agreement, Betancourt said that the tran-

saction would “unleash that potential to the great benefit of both Venezuelans and Americans.”

“Mr. Betancourt has been in the Venezuelan oil industry for more than 15

years with a consistent track record of success, most recently at the helm of NABEP, where he rapidly scaled the company's production,” the company said in the statement, adding it has a near-term goal of increasing production to more than 1 million barrels of oil per day.

Others more cautious Others may be more cautious, illustrating the uphill battle President Donald Trump faces to convince major U.S. oil companies, particularly ExxonMobil and ConocoPhillips, to invest in Venezuela and quickly expand the country's oil production.

Both companies left Venezuela in 2007 after their assets were nationalised by the government of former

President Hugo Chavez, and both have repeatedly said that their requirements of legal certainty and contract sanctity have not yet been met to re-enter the country.

Trump told reporters on Monday that Exxon was among the companies going into Venezuela, without elaborating.

ExxonMobil declined to comment when asked about Trump's statement. A ConocoPhillips spokesperson referred to an earlier statement that said any investment decision would be guided by a number of factors, including policy stability and adherence to the rule of law.

U.S. likely competitor The planned structure and the massive assets NABEP

could accumulate in the OPEC country are raising concerns that American oil companies could face competition from the U.S. government itself in Venezuela, the sources added.

That could add more obstacles to Trump's goal of increasing Venezuela's oil output and exports to boost U.S. reserves, said Alejo Czerwonko, chief investment officer of emerging markets for UBS.

“You would need sizeable investment and know-how from the likes of Exxon and ConocoPhillips,” he said. “How do you lure these companies into the country?”

“There's still a lot of unknowns and confusing elements,” said Radhika Bansal, a senior vice president at Rystad Energy.

KOROR

China warns of ‘consequences’ after Taiwan envoys attend summit



China warned Taiwan of “consequences” after Taiwanese officials attended a Pacific Islands Forum event in Palau alongside Beijing representatives. China called Taiwan’s participation inappropriate, while major powers had already been urged to avoid turning the regional summit into a geopolitical contest. AP

JERUSALEM

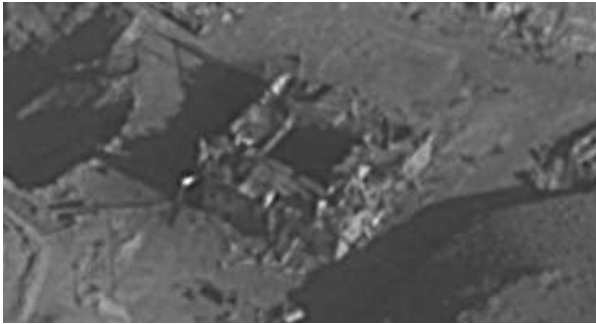
Israel signs \$3.5-bn arms deal to build air defence shield in Greece



Israel on Monday signed a \$3.5 billion arms deal with Greece, one of Israel’s biggest ever sales at a time when it faces criticism in much of the world. The agreement will be part of the new “Achilles Shield” aerial defence system for Greece. The Achilles Shield will include Israeli-made anti-missile, anti-aircraft and anti-drone systems. AFP

VIENNA

UN report finds Syria was building a nuclear reactor in Deir el-Zour



UN nuclear watchdog inspectors found that “former Syrian authorities failed to report nuclear material, facilities and activities as required under safeguards agreements”, a confidential report said. Inspectors of IAEA confirmed reactor infrastructure at Deir el-Zour and verified about “73 tonnes of natural uranium”. AP

LAS VEGAS

Former gang member found guilty of murdering rapper Tupac Shakur



Duane “Keffe D” Davis, a former Los Angeles gang leader, was found guilty on Monday by a Las Vegas court of the 1996 murder of rapper Tupac Shakur. Thirty years after the rap legend’s death, the jury found Davis, 63, guilty of murder after just a few hours of deliberation. Sentencing is scheduled for October 13. AFP

‘India needs to be vocal on international law breaches’

‘India continues its development and humanitarian assistance with Palestinians; it continues to voice its compliance with the idea of two-state solution; and we expect India, being a friend of both Israel and Palestine, to push more towards respecting a world order based on international law,’ says Palestine Foreign Minister, adding that Palestinians today are worse off than they were before October 7

INTERVIEW

Varsen Aghabekian Shahin

Stanly Johny

India needs to be more vocal about violations of international law and use its global weight to push for peace between Israel and the Palestinians, Palestinian Foreign Minister Varsen Aghabekian Shahin has said, while urging New Delhi to examine arms transfers to Israel seriously. In an interview with *The Hindu*, Ms. Shahin said the situation in the West Bank, where settler violence is spreading, is “very bad”. Edited excerpts:

Reports of settler violence are emerging almost every day from the West Bank. How serious is the situation there?

Well, the situation is really bad and it’s getting worse because settler terrorism is part and parcel of an Israeli policy aimed at erasing the Palestinian presence in the occupied Palestinian territory. It has been ongoing since day one of the occupation, but today, we see that settler terrorism is spiking. And it is spiking because settler terrorists are emboldened by Ministers in the Israeli government who are themselves settlers. They arm the settlers, and provide them with money. It is about erasing the Palestinian presence and it is done in a systematic way.

What is the Palestinian Authority’s view of the Trump peace plan for Gaza?

Our utmost priority was and still is stopping the bleeding in Gaza. I mean, Gaza has been genocided for almost three years now. And the priority is to bring some peace and security to the devastated people in

Gaza. Everything in Gaza today has been destroyed. And people require immediate assistance. In that sense, we have welcomed the peace plan. Today, we would like to see that the terms of the peace plan are respected. Hamas said it is ready to give up the arms; no matter how you look at it, there is some responsiveness in that regard. Now, the ball is in the Israeli court.

Do you think President Trump is serious about the Israeli pull-back from Gaza?

If he put that in his plan and that plan is his legacy, then I would assume that he is serious about it. And if somebody can do it today, it would be President Trump.

Is the two-state solution still alive?

There is no other solution. The other solution is a one-state solution, if Israel is



adamant on not having two states, which gives Israel 78% of historic Palestine. Israel does not want to give any of the occupied land, but if it wants to live in peace and security, it needs to become a normal state. Today it is not a normal state. Today, it voices its expansionist, colonialist ideology and infringes on the rights of neighbouring countries. This is an expansionist state that does not comply with international law.

Israeli officials would say their hard military response is necessitated by Palestinian or Hamas

and destroy 80% of Gaza. This is not acceptable.

Do you think Palestinians are worse off today than they were before October 7?

Today, the situation is very hard. Of course, we have 2 million people in Gaza living under immense devastation. They don’t even have their basic needs met. In the West Bank, the entrenchment of occupation is much stronger and the situation on the ground is much worse.

India has historically supported the Palestinian cause, and its position today is that it backs a two-state solution. But India’s position has also evolved over the years and it has built strong bilateral ties with Israel. How do you assess India’s position today?

Look, we have a very longstanding relationship with India. India was among the

first countries that recognised [Palestine]. It is a friend of Israel as well, and we have no issue with that. They need to be vocal about what is right and what is wrong, and they need to be vocal about violations of international law. This is what is expected of India. India continues its development and humanitarian assistance with the Palestinians.

It continues to voice its compliance with the idea of the two-state solution. And we expect India, being a friend of both [Israel and Palestine] and a country with significant global weight, to push more towards respecting a world order based on international law and [ensuring there are] no violations of that law.

There was a recent Amnesty International report claiming that more than 2,500 shipments of arms and ammunition were sent from India to Israel after October 7. What is

your response to this report?

Any report that comes out from [Amnesty] or any other international organisation needs to be looked at very seriously. Such reports have a lot of credibility. And today, arms dealings with the State of Israel need to be questioned because we have obligations. All states have obligations based on international law, and our position and the world’s position must be guided by international law, and continuing transfer of arms to the state of Israel might violate it. The ICJ said very clearly that there is plausible genocide in Gaza, and any arms transferred to Israel might be contributing to the terror there. We need to be very careful when we deal with arms with the state of Israel and this is what is expected from India as well. Read the full interview at: [newsth.live/palestinefm](#) Video can be accessed at: [newsth.live/vidinterview](#)

U.K. ex-PM Starmer to step down as MP

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

Former British Prime Minister Keir Starmer announced that he would step down as MP and focus on “international affairs” among other areas, even as his successor Andy Burnham faced lawmakers for the first time in the House of Commons since ousting Mr. Starmer from office in July.

Mr. Starmer, who was Prime Minister for just over two years and an MP for 11 years, represents the central London constituency of Holborn & St. Pancras. In a resignation announcement published on social media, Mr. Starmer said he

Starmer says he would back whoever Labour chose as his successor in Parliament

would now focus on other issues such as international affairs, including defence, security, trade and technology. A former public prosecutor, he said that he would also work to prevent violence against women and girls.

Mr. Starmer said he supported Mr. Burnham and added that he would also back whoever Labour chose as his successor in Parliament, ahead of a by-poll for his constituency.

Nepal flash flood toll crosses 1,000 as security forces recover more bodies

Press Trust of India
KATHMANDU

The death toll from the devastating flash floods in Nepal rose to 1,003 on Tuesday, with security forces recovering more bodies from eight districts of the country, officials said.

Rescuers struggled to trace those stranded amid intermittent rainfall and a fresh flood alert as water levels rose in rivers across eastern, central and western Nepal.

Around 4,000 people, including 583 foreigners and several security personnel, still remain missing, while nearly 12,000 have been rescued, the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) said.



Rescuers wait for a helicopter to evacuate the dead after they found 24 bodies inside a mud-buried house in Betrawati. PRABHAT KHANAL

Flash floods, triggered by a collapse or avalanche of ice and rock near the Nepal-Tibet border, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal on August 26.

The Bhotekoshi River, which flows south from the Himalayan border region, carried the floodwaters downstream, sweeping away homes, vehicles, roads and bridges and damaging hydropower projects.

Nepalese authorities on Tuesday issued a fresh alert over the risk of floods in several districts across eastern, central and western parts of the country, urging people living near rivers to remain vigilant and take precautionary measures. There is a high possibility of flash floods in Nuwakot and Rasuwa districts, where water flow in smaller rivers and streams is expected to rise, according to a notice issued by the NDRRMA.

The Nepalese government has mobilised more than 21,300 security personnel for relief operations.

‘Indian citizen among 12 killed in Russian attacks on Ukraine’

Press Trust of India
LONDON

An Indian citizen was among 12 people killed in the latest Russian attacks on Ukraine, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Tuesday, as drones and ballistic missiles struck several cities in the eastern European nation, damaging residential buildings and civilian infrastructure.

Since Monday evening, guided aerial bomb and drone strikes have continued against Odesa city and the surrounding region, leaving thousands of families without electricity, Mr. Zelenskyy said in a



Volodymyr Zelenskyy

social media post. Mr. Zelenskyy said dozens of people were injured in the attacks, which also hit Kyiv, Odesa, Kherson, Donetsk, Zaporizhzhia, Kharkiv, Chernihiv, Zhytomyr, Sumy and Dnipro regions.

Xi urges SCO member states to make security a key priority

Press Trust of India
BISHKEK

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Tuesday called on the members of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) to make security a key priority and crack down on terrorism, separatism and extremism, transnational organised crimes, drug trafficking and telecom fraud.

“We should stay committed to taking security as a key goal, and foster an environment of common



Xi Jinping

security. We should pursue coordinated measures to tackle traditional and non-traditional security threats,” Mr. Xi said while

addressing the SCO summit in the Kyrgyz capital attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Russian President Vladimir Putin and others.

“We should crack down on the three forces of terrorism, separatism and extremism, transnational organised crime, drug trafficking, and telecom fraud,” he added. The SCO member states should strengthen cooperation on information security, bio-security, and outer space security, Mr. Xi said.

Water must never be weaponised, says Sharif

Press Trust of India
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Tuesday said that water was the “lifeblood” of the region and it must never be weaponised, highlighting the issue of the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT).

Mr. Sharif was speaking at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit in the Kyrgyz capital, *Dawn* reported.

U.S. hits targets along Strait of Hormuz; Iran’s Armed Forces vow ‘crushing blows’

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

The U.S. military hit targets in Iran on Tuesday after it said Tehran tried to attack commercial ships and American forces in the West Asia, as hostilities flare once again in an intermittent war that has lasted more than six months.

The U.S. strikes, and others on Sunday, abruptly ended a month without military action and threatens to fully reprise a conflict that has spiked global

oil prices and posed political problems for Republicans in November’s midterm congressional elections. The renewed fighting comes after President Donald Trump appeared to pivot last month toward trying to bend Iran to his will through economic sanctions. “If the failed Nation of Iran retaliates for this very justified attack, they will be hit again at a much harder and higher level, but it will not be the biggest attack of them all, that is waiting in the wings,” Mr. Trump warned on social media after U.S. Central Command announced the strikes.

Iran’s Armed Forces General Staff and its joint military command, however, said the armed forces would deliver what they described as “crushing and

devastating blows” against the U.S. Iranian state television said the United States struck a fishmeal factory on Qeshm Island in the Strait of Hormuz as well as several civilian targets in Hormozgan province. Earlier on Tuesday, Iran’s President Masoud Pezeshkian, at the SCO summit in Bishkek, said that Tehran will immediately reciprocate if the U.S. returns to its commitments under an interim deal signed in June.

Japan to ease rules on overtime work amid labour crisis

Thailand's Pattaya awaits over 5,000 sailors of *U.S.S. Abraham Lincoln*

A large aircraft carrier is shown sailing on the ocean. The ship is grey and has a long, flat deck. It is moving from left to right, leaving a white wake behind it. The sky is blue and clear, and the water is a deep blue. There are some small structures and antennas on the ship's superstructure.

ing system is sloppy, could se millions: whistleblower

A large group of people, including Rev. Jesse Jackson, are marching in a protest. They are holding a banner that reads "ACTION NETWORK" and "DRUM". A man in the foreground wears a white t-shirt with the text "BLACK FOLKS DON'T HAVE THEMSELVES FROM". Other people in the background are holding signs, including one that says "PROTEST THE BALLOT" and another that says "LDF".

Ride home



Election campaign heating up in France as summer vacation season ends

INBRIEF



Barcelona confirms Jesus arrival from Arsenal

Barcelona signed Brazilian forward Gabriel Jesus from Arsenal on Tuesday on a deal until 2029, after it was unable to pry Julian Alvarez from Atletico Madrid. “Barcelona and Arsenal have reached a deal for the Brazilian striker Gabriel Jesus,” said the Catalan club in a statement, with Spanish media reporting that Barca paid the Gunners around €10 million. Jesus arrives to bolster an attack weakened by the departures of Robert Lewandowski and Ferran Torres earlier this summer.

Unnati loses in first round of China Masters badminton

Unnati Hooda fell at the first hurdle in women’s singles, while men’s doubles pair Hariharan Amsakarunan and M.R. Arjun retired at the first-game interval of their opening-round match at the China Masters Super 750 badminton tournament in Shenzhen on Tuesday.

The results (first round): Women: Kim Ga Eun bt Unnati Hooda 21-10, 21-18; **Men: Doubles:** Chen Bo Yang & Liu Yi bt Hariharan Amsakarunan & M.R. Arjun 8-11 (retd.).



Villa signs Senegalese winger Mbaye from PSG

Aston Villa signed Senegal winger Ibrahim Mbaye from Paris Saint-Germain (PSG) in a deal worth a reported £47 million on Tuesday. Mbaye played 31 times in all competitions for PSG last season.

LIVE TELECAST

Duleep Trophy (semifinal), Day 4: JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.
Women’s T20 Asia Cup: Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 8 p.m.
US Open: SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 8.30 p.m. & 4.30 a.m. (Thursday)

Arsenal stays flawless; Barcelona on fire



Decisive: Saka bundles in Arsenal’s winner against Aston Villa. AP

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
BIRMINGHAM

Arsenal extended its flawless start to the Premier League season as Bukayo Saka sealed the champion’s 1-0 win against troubled Aston Villa on Monday. Saka’s second-half strike at Villa Park wrapped up Arsenal’s second successive victory.

In a statement of intent to its title rivals, Mikel Arteta’s side has taken maximum points from its opening two games without conceding a goal.

The only concern for Arteta was a potential injury that forced Declan Rice to limp off in the closing stag-

es. Lamine Yamal and Raphinha both struck twice as Barcelona beat Rayo Vallecano 5-2 on Monday to continue its perfect start to the campaign.

Sergio Camello netted a brace for the visitors at Camp Nou but Hansi Flick’s Barca managed to record a third win from three matches from an entertaining battle.

With his first goal, Yamal, 19, hit the milestone of 50 for the club – two years younger than Barcelona icon Lionel Messi was when he managed the feat.

Dutch international Doonyell Malen was the hero again as Roma ran Lecce ragged in Serie A on Monday with a 4-0 away win, in which the in-form forward scored twice.

Dhoni fan Prithika getting ready for Asian Games debut

The youngster is sharpening her skills along with experienced teammates Jyothi and Chikitha at the Sonipat camp; she believes the Archery Premier League stint will stand her in good stead

ARCHERY

Y.B. Sarangi

A self-confessed M.S. Dhoni fan, 17-year-old compound archer Prithika Pradeep is inspired by the cricket legend’s calmness as she prepares for her Asian Games debut.

A World youth silver medallist and World Cup Stage silver medallist in 2025, Prithika made her mark by topping the Asiad selection trials and then securing individual bronze and team silver at the World Cup Stage-4 in Madrid this year.

The Nagercoil-born Prithika, who was brought up in Pune and took to archery as a hobby because she liked the name of the sport, is sharpening her skills along with experienced teammates V. Jyothi Surekha and Chikitha Taniparthi at the Sonipat camp.

“After winning the Madrid medals, I have gained in confidence. But now



Role model: Prithika says she likes the former Indian cricket team captain’s mindset, calmness and quick decision-making.

that is over. I have to focus on the Asian Games. Here, I get to learn by training

with the seniors. They share their experience. Jyothi didi tells me to stay

TN sprinters Neil and Mrithika shatter 100m records in National youth athletics

Press Trust of India
LUDHIANA

Tamil Nadu sprinters shone on the opening day of the National Youth Athletics Championships as they won the 100m gold in both the men’s and women’s sections here on Tuesday.

Promising sprinter Neil Samraj R. dominated the men’s 100m dash. His winning time of 10.46s was better than the previous youth National record of 10.63s set by Anshu Rajak in 2023 in Coimbatore.



Neil Samraj.

T. Mrithika claimed the women’s 100m gold medal, clocking 11.78s, bettering the previous meet re-



Mrithika.

cord of 11.80s set by Dutee Chand in 2012 in Bengaluru. Mrithika was the only sprinter in the final to

break the 12-second barrier.

Suchithra S. of Karnataka edged past Saawari Kulkarni (Maharashtra) to win the silver with a time of 12.03s. Saawari clocked 12.09s for the bronze.

The results: Men: 100m: 1. Neil Samraj R. (TN) 10.46s; 2. Mehebabul Ahamed (WB) 10.74s; 3. Pushpendar Kumar (Del) 10.81s.
Women: 100m: 1. T. Mrithika (TN) 11.78s; 2. Suchithra S. (Kar) 12.03s, 3. Saawari Kulkarni (Mah) 12.09s. **Discus:** 1. Oshin (Har) 45.98m, 2. Dimpny Saini (UP) 43.22m, 3. Mansi Dangi (Har) 43.09m.

Konstas, Handscomb in Australia-A squad for tour of India

Press Trust of India
SYDNEY

Australia on Tuesday named A squads, featuring several players with senior international experience, including pacer Ben Dwarshuis, Sam Konstas and Nathan McSweeney, for the series against India-A in Puducherry later this month.

The first four-day game will begin on September 22, with the second ‘Test’ scheduled to start on September 29.

The one-dayers will be

played on October 6, 9 and 11.

Australia-A squads: Four-day matches: Brendan Doggett, Jack Edwards, Peter Handscomb, Sam Harper, Liam Hatcher, Campbell Kellaway, Sam Konstas, Nathan McSweeney, Todd Murphy, Fergus O’Neill, Josh Philippe, Jhye Richardson, Corey Rocchiccioli, Jason Sangha, Liam Scott.

One-day games: Mahli Beardman, Nikhil Chaudhary, Ben Dwarshuis, Jack Edwards, Aaron Hardie, Spencer Johnson, Sam Konstas, Nathan McSweeney, Todd Murphy, Mitch Owen, Josh Philippe, Tanveer Sangha, Liam Scott, Lachlan Shaw.

India to field four surfers at Asiad

Jayantho Sengupta
CHENNAI

India will field a four-member surfing squad at the 2026 Asian Games, ending the uncertainty over the country’s participation in the sport’s maiden appearance at the continental event.

Kishore Kumar and Sivraj Babu will compete in the men’s shortboard event, while Kamali Moorthy and Sugar Shanthi Banarse will represent India in the women’s

competition.

The surfers were not included in an earlier list of cleared Indian participants released by the Sports Ministry, while the selection dispute involving Ramesh Budihal was before the Karnataka High Court.

Although the surfing federation had forwarded the four names in June, Budihal challenged the process through which Sivraj was chosen as the second confirmed male athlete, with Budihal placed as the first reserve.

Marsh, Head return for Zimbabwe and SA ODIs

Press Trust of India
SYDNEY

Top-order batter Marnus Labuschagne was a notable omission while skipper Mitchell Marsh and fellow opener Travis Head returned to the 17-member Australia squad for the ODI series against Zimbabwe and South Africa later this month. Marsh will lead the side in the three-match ODI series in Zimbabwe before

regular ODI and Test captain Pat Cummins returns to take charge in South Africa along with Mitchell Starc.

The squad: Mitchell Marsh, Pat Cummins (South Africa only), Xavier Bartlett, Alex Carey, Cooper Connolly, Joel Davies, Nathan Ellis, Cameron Green, Josh Hazlewood, Travis Head, Josh Inglis, Spencer Johnson, Oliver Peake, Matthew Renshaw, Billy Stanlake, Mitchell Starc (SA only) and Adam Zampa.

TVS Motor Company extends partnership with Angkor Tiger FC



Ambitious: Angkor Tiger FC finished third last year in the Cambodian Premier League. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

TVS Motor Company (TVSM), part of TVS VENU, has extended its partnership with the Cambodian Premier League team, Angkor Tiger Football Club.

The 2026-27 season partnership is the third consecutive year of continued collaboration and support from TVS Motor Company to Angkor Tiger.

The club, based in Siem Reap, is part-owned by Indian firm SkaSports and competes in the top division Cambodian Premier League. The club finished third in the Cambodia Premier League in 2025-26.

Speaking on the partnership, James Chan, senior vice-president and Head of ASEAN region at TVS Motor Company, said: “Three seasons in, our journey with Angkor Tiger FC continues to be rooted

in a shared vision of ambition and resilience for Cambodia’s youth.

“We are honoured to stand with the team and its fans once again, celebrating the power of sport to unite, inspire, and transform communities across the nation We’re delighted to continue our partnership with TVS for a third consecutive season. They believed in our vision from the very beginning, and we’re proud of how far we’ve come together. We look forward to building on that success in the season ahead,” said Rohit Ramesh, Director, SkaSports.

Akihiro Kato, Owner and Chairperson of Angkor Tiger FC added, “TVS has been more than a sponsor – they have been a trusted partner who shares our vision of building a sustainable football club that inspires the people of Cambodia.”

Mumbai captaincy a matter of pride: Lad

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

For Siddhesh Lad, the last six weeks have brought two milestones that have little to do with runs scored or wickets taken. The birth of his son Shiva has been followed by the Mumbai captaincy, even as the senior batter continues to work his way back from an injury layoff.

Lad – who was Mumbai’s highest run-scorer in the Ranji Trophy last season – has been appointed the team’s captain for the forthcoming Ranji Trophy season, replacing Shardul Thakur. The change, according to chief selector Rajesh Pawar, is aimed at reducing the workload on Shardul, who remains an integral all-rounder in the side.

For Lad, who has previously led Mumbai as a stand-in captain in six matches, the opportunity to take charge for an entire season is a source of pride. “It’s a proud moment for me and the family. Having soaked in the Mumbai cricket culture and ethos, we all know how crucial the First Class tradition is. I have led Mumbai before, but to be appointed as the full season’s captain is a matter of pride,” Lad told *The Hindu* on Tuesday.

“A team like Mumbai – with so many senior



Race against time: Lad says his immediate priority is to get fit before Mumbai’s season-opener. FILE PHOTO: EMMANUEL YOGINI

players, be it internationals or India-A or IPL regulars – doesn’t really need to be captained. One just has to keep on reminding them about game situations at times. I just hope that we can cross the winning barrier this time around, something that the team fell short of in the last two seasons.”

Lad’s relationship with Shardul should ensure that the captaincy transition does not become a dividing line. Shardul is a protégé of Lad’s father Dinesh and has been an important sounding board for Siddhesh.

“Shardul has always been and will remain an integral part and a match-

winner in this team. He is a leader by example and has always been my sounding board,” Lad said.

“Our bond goes way beyond the designations, and I am sure he will continue to be a bedrock of the team.”

Lad’s immediate priority, however, is getting fit. His rehabilitation after a shoulder dislocation during the T20 Mumbai final in June is progressing well, and he hopes to be ready before Mumbai’s season-opener against Chandigarh.

“My rehab is well on course. I hope to be ready to go well in time before the season-opener,” he said.

Vivek Krishnan

Tributes will keep pouring in. Highlights will be replayed on loop. Memories will linger for eternity.

But the magic of watching Lionel Messi in real time in Argentina’s iconic sky blue and white stripes, spreading immeasurable joy to millions around the globe, is now a thing of the past.

The forward, all of five feet and seven inches in height but a towering figure when it came to his deeds on the football turf, has walked into the sunset after 21 years of carrying the South American nation’s expectations with grace and grandeur. Through those years, whilst playing 207 times, scoring 125 goals and winning one World Cup and two Copa America titles, the 39-year-old’s ability to illuminate a game with his stardust stayed undiluted.

A little more of Messi’s genius – be it his nimble-footed manoeuvres, magnetic control of the ball, sudden burst of speed, 360-degree vision and wide range of passing – will be glimpsed in whatever is left of his contract with Major League Soccer (MLS) club Inter Miami. But it won’t be the same as when the Argentine demigod dazzled with the ball at his feet and carved a lasting legacy at the international level, much like how Diego Maradona did for Argentina and Pele for Brazil before him.

Nothing more to give

The exit, which was announced via a long and emotional Instagram post on Monday, came as no bolt from the blue. A little more than a month after losing to Spain in the World Cup final and a few weeks after his father Jorge’s passing away, Messi had no more to give by his own admission. That was telling, for the great man, even at 39, had not shied away over the summer in North America from putting his heart and soul into trying to win a second straight World Cup for his country. He came up only narrowly short as Spain dominated with its fluid, possession-heavy style to win 1-0 in the final, a reminder that perfect farewells tend to elude even perfectionists of Messi’s ilk.

“Time is running short, chapters come to a close, and this is one that hurts me deeply. I love, have loved, and will always love being part of the national team. I’ve given everything I had; I have nothing left to give, and besides, there are some great young players coming up who deserve to be here,” Messi wrote.

As he revealed in his post, the retirement note was penned on July 21, two days after the conclusion of the World Cup. The death of his father and first coach, who had sacrificed the familiarity of life in Rosario to take his teenage son to



Messi and Argentina: A legacy that will stand the test of time

For 21 years, the left-footed forward from Rosario was *La Albiceleste*’s heartbeat, navigating his way through ups and downs with remarkable poise and inimitable brilliance. Having announced his international retirement via a post on social media on Monday, the 39-year-old brings an end to a career that entailed a record 207 appearances, 125 goals, one World Cup and two Copa America titles

GETTY IMAGES



Barcelona, on August 8 reinforced the feeling that the time was right to hang up his boots.

In a way, the fact that Messi’s time in the Argentine jersey concluded with heartbreak in the World Cup final was an apt encapsulation of his journey. The first half of his international career, which began with a sending-off on debut against Hungary in 2005, was far from a bed of roses after all. As he dribbled past defenders and netted a truckload of goals on his way to a wave of success with Barcelona at club level in the early years, a sense of alienation with fans in his homeland grew stronger. Having left for the famed surroundings of La Masia, Barcelona’s youth academy, at 13, Messi’s allegiances were routinely brought into question.

The Maradona shadow

That Messi was projected as the heir to the throne vacated by Maradona, the undisputed darling of the masses for his leading role in lifting the 1986 World Cup in Mexico, made the protege’s job all the more harder. As Argentina hurtled to an early exit in the 2010 World Cup in South Africa, incidentally under Maradona’s watch as coach, Messi, by now wearing No. 10 on his back, was the scapegoat that fans vented their ire towards.

In his propensity to produce a piece of magic out of thin air, Messi was unparalleled in the modern world. Others may go on to rack up the extraordinary numbers that he managed, but it is hard to envision anyone doing it with as much flair and elegance

The narrative received further ammunition even as Messi guided Argentina to the finals of the World Cup in 2014 and the Copa America in 2015 and 2016. The abyss was seemingly reached in the 2016 continental showpiece, when his penalty miss in the shootout of the summit clash against Chile in New Jersey condemned the proud nation to its third straight runner-up finish.

In the immediate aftermath, Messi, having grown weary of the relentless scrutiny, decided to quit altogether. “For me, the national team is over. I’ve done all I can. It hurts not to be a champion. I think this is best for everyone. First of all for me, and then for everyone else. There are many people who want that, who are not satisfied, as we are not satisfied, I suppose, with reaching the final and not winning it,” he anguished right after the Copa America final.

This was on June 26, 2016 – two days

after he had turned 29.

If he hadn’t had a change of mind soon after, how his legacy would have been construed makes for an intriguing what-if. Yes, he would have still been feted for the trophies and individual accolades accomplished with Barcelona. But would he have stood atop the pantheon of all-time greats alongside Pele and Maradona?

In hindsight, the knee-jerk exit, which was reversed three months later, ended up galvanising the country in support of Messi. His future teammates, most notably Enzo Fernandez who made a desperate plea on social media for the superstar to rethink his decision, would enter the fray with the burning desire to assist the attacker in flipping the fortunes of the national team. The fans, previously ambivalent to the skipper, also came together behind their main protagonist.

It kicked off a period of dominance of the kind that Messi & Co. had been craving. They tasted blood with victory in the Copa America in 2021, putting an end to a 28-year drought for a marquee title at the senior level.

Winning the ultimate prize

Even then, the absence of a World Cup – the holy grail of sporting events – hovered like a dark cloud over the forward going

into Qatar in 2022. Cold logic suggested that Messi, who was 35 and hadn’t succeeded in four previous attempts to hoist the ultimate prize, was well past his prime to spur Argentina to glory.

The start to the campaign was disconcertingly shaky as Argentina went down to Saudi Arabia, but then Messi, a tad slower but no less sublime and skilful, showed his wondrous capability thereafter. The slow walk across the turf became something of a signature, but if there was a sliver of space to exploit, Messi, alert as ever to the movements of his opponents, would pounce and burst forward in a flash.

He scored seven goals in West Asia, but his assists were just as eye-catching. Remember the defence-splitting pass for Nahuel Molina to score against the Netherlands, or the confluence of power and panache with which he waltzed past a significantly younger Josko Gvardiol to tee up Julian Alvarez for Argentina’s third goal against Croatia.

Cut to the just-concluded global spectacle, Messi, as if untouched by the passage of time, was remarkably wielding the same influence for the defending champion. He scored as many as eight times, taking his overall tally in the World Cup to 21 goals.

In his propensity to produce a piece of magic out of thin air, Messi was unparalleled in the modern world. Others may go on to rack up the extraordinary numbers that he managed, but it is hard to envision anyone doing it with as much flair and elegance.

In his sentimental farewell note on Monday, Messi ensured to thank all those who lent a helping hand in his fulfilling journey. It will be grossly remiss of us to not reciprocate in kind. *Gracias, Messi!*

THE GIST

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▼ In the just-concluded global spectacle, Messi, as if untouched by the passage of time, was remarkably wielding the same influence for the team

